the stars, the moons, and everything in between

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32908366.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Double Trouble/money

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (but he's a droid), Light Hope (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), MDA3 (you'll see!), Huntara

Additional Tags:
the one and only catradora space cowboys AU, maybe also a star wars AU if you squint, Space AU, catradora

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by heartofmara

Summary

Running from an inevitable fate, Adora - also known as She-Ra, Princess of Power - has enlisted in the Rebellion's efforts to displace the Glorious Imperial Army of the Horde. When her ship runs out of fuel in the most inconvenient part of the galaxy, she must rely on the kindness of an elusive stranger, a girl with daggers in her sleeves and secrets between her teeth. In the end, the two must reckon with their individual debts and destinies to help balance the universe... or not. **a catradora space cowboys AU

Notes

About two weeks ago, I lost a bet to @ikeameatballs and received the prompt "catradora space cowboys AU" as my punishment. What was meant to be just a 1,000 word one-shot turned into a five-part (the sixth will be an epilogue!) story about the SPOP gang in space. Thanks to the wonderful edits of @historianadora, I now have a coherent tale that I'm incredibly excited to share! Without further ado, enjoy "the stars, the moons, and everything in between"!

Part I: The Courage of Stars

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"SCREEEEECH!"

Adora jolted awake. She clutched the threads of the raggedy blanket in between her trembling fingers as she waited for her consciousness to chase away the remnants of her nightmare.

She had been back in the Crystal Castle, suffocating in a glittering sea of purple and blue platinum. Light Hope's cold, metallic voice had echoed through the training room as Adora picked up her sword.

"You must let go, Adora. Let go of your fear and embrace your destiny."

Even though it had been years since she had set foot in the Castle, or even thought about her supposed 'destiny,' Adora wanted to curl in on herself and scream until Light Hope's voice was drowned out by her raw and bleeding cries.

The floor of the ship jolted underneath her, bringing her back to reality. From somewhere in the distance, Adora heard the piercing siren that indicated the hatch on the docking bay was opening.

"Bow?" She cried out, scrambling out of her cot. In the dim light of the ship's small sleeping quarters she could make out the neon yellow numbers of the clocks that sat atop every doorway, vigilant guardians of their tight schedule:

23:45

Adora reached under her pillow and grabbed her sword, sliding it into the leather scabbard she kept strapped to her back at all times. They weren't due on Krytis for another seven and a half

hours and their route had them traveling directly through the Yawning Gap, aptly named for its ability to lull flyers into a near comatose state of boredom from its lack of planets, meteors, or even a waste dumping ground.

(She also heard there had once been stars along the journey to Krytis, but she had been born long after they all disappeared.)

She wrenched open the door and blinked rapidly as the harsh fluorescent lights accosted her eyes. She grabbed her wide-brimmed hat from its hook next to the door and slid it onto her head, but still had to blink away tears from the sudden change in lighting. She doubted Bow had unintentionally opened up the hatch to the docking bay, which meant they were in for some trouble.

Adora grinned. She was overdue for a spot of trouble, and taking out whatever idiots were trying to board their ship in the middle of the Yawning Gap might just satisfy that itch.

"Adora, hold on!" Bow's voice called from the cockpit. The ship lurched to the side again, causing their cleaning droid, MDA3, to let out a series of concerned beeps and boops.

"Hang in there, buddy," Adora called over her shoulder as she made her way to the cockpit. She didn't realize MDA3 was behind her until a jolt of the ship had her careening backwards right onto their aluminum-reinforced head.

"BEEEEP!"

"Sorry, MD," she patted their side reassuringly even as they rolled indignantly away from her and towards the cockpit. She followed, keeping one hand on the ventilation shafts rimming the narrow passageway so she wouldn't lose her balance again.

When she arrived she found Bow frantically pressing the glowing red comms button with one hand, the other stuck in a white-knuckled grip on the steering controls.

“This is oh-two-oh-one-dash-Darla requesting information as to who is trying to board us, over.” Bow waited for a moment before sighing and slumping back in his seat, allowing his hands to fall from the dash. Adora whipped her head up to see that their ship had been ground to a complete halt with nothing but an onyx expanse to greet them.

“You wanna tell me what’s going on?”

Bow scratched at the back of his neck nervously, banging his elbow on the routing controls behind him. At a meager one yard wide and two yards deep, the cockpit barely fit one human, let alone *two* humans and a rotund cleaning droid with over sixty-three detachable appendages.

“I think we’re being boarded by the Horde.”

“*Krayt*, Bow- the Horde?”

“Now hold on- don’t be having your kittens by the litter,” Bow intoned and Adora crossed her arms. Even after three years of friendship, she still didn’t understand some of the phrases the Chari-borne and raised pilot said.

“We don’t know that they know we have illegal fuel onboard. It could just be a routine inspection,” he offered.

Adora frowned deeply. “In the middle of the Yawning Gap?”

“What better place to get to know some friendly space travelers!”

“From *Bright Moon*, Bow,” she reminded him. “The documents that Glimmer forged for us before we left say that we’re from Bright Moon.”

“Well, there are dozens of bright moons,” he said lamely.

Adora fought the urge to roll her eyes. “We need this shipment-“

She was interrupted by a loud clank, followed by complete silence.

Bow's eyes widened and his cheeks paled. "The docking bay," he whispered, but Adora was already creeping out of the cockpit and down towards the cargo hold. She drew out her sword and held it in front of her, keeping a cautious eye on the divet in the wall where the docking bay lay hidden in shadow. When she heard two loud clicks behind her, she knew Bow had drawn his compound bow constructed of Bantha bone dyed a deep navy with golden stripes along its S-shaped curve. Although the apparatus was traditional, Bow had retrofitted each arrow in his quiver to perform a unique task, such as sticking to a wall like a star barnacle to the underbelly of their ship or shattering into several tiny arrows that whistled through the air as they struck true.

Adora ran her thumb along the biometric scanner at the base of her sword, causing the laser to illuminate the dim space with a piercing blue radiance. She felt the other changes- the armor growing to encircle her forehead and the stretch in her calves- as she grew to a height taller than even Light Hope herself, but barely paid them any attention as she took a defensive stance facing the docking bay hatch.

After all, transforming into She-Ra was a necessity more than a spectacle, a wholly ordinary task rather than a glorious flaunt of the transcendent power she possessed.

If Light Hope could see her now she'd probably faint, but Adora had more pressing concerns than the reminder of everything she had been promised... and then gave up.

A hiss rattled through the cargo hold as steam began to pour forth from the cracks in between the hatch and the walls. As the hatch slowly opened, a voice called out, "Please desist, we come in peace."

Adora glanced over at Bow and saw her skepticism reflected on his face.

Through the hatch stepped a young woman in the red and white armor of the Horde, her short brown dreadlocks tied back into a

low ponytail. Her hazel eyes fixed on Adora, then Bow, then MDA3, who rolled behind Adora's leg.

"Is this all of your crew?" she said, disbelieving. Behind her, a tall lizard-man appeared, pointing a surprisingly large gun at Adora.

"Why are we being boarded? The Horde has no jurisdiction here," she protested.

The woman's eyes lingered on Adora's sword, no doubt entranced by the glimmering blue laser that had replaced a traditional blade.

"The Horde will soon have jurisdiction over this entire fucking galaxy, and the one next door," she bragged.

"What Adora meant to say is that we already requested clearance through the Gap from the Fantuthians," Bow offered. "So we're confused as to why you stopped us along our pre-authorized flight path."

The lizard-man's eyes flicked behind Adora before he grunted something unintelligible at the woman. Adora didn't need to look over her shoulder to realize that he had seen the stack of fuel containers secured to the ground by a bunch of loose wires Adora commandeered from a polite (but chatty) old woman on Fantuth.

"Is that Horde-sanctioned Thulite?" She inquired.

"Would you believe us if we said yes?" Adora tried.

The woman flicked her hand and the lizard-man began shooting at them. Adora deflected the blows with her sword as MDA3 let out a screeching "BEEEP!" Bow loosed an arrow from his quiver that fell at the woman's feet and quickly wrapped around her ankles, binding them together. Adora charged forward, careful not to bang her head against the top of the hatch, and swung at the woman. More swiftly than she had anticipated, the Horde soldier jabbed a taser into her side, causing Adora's teeth to rattle as her muscles clamped up in an unsteady orchestra of electric pulses.

Despite the sensation that her bones had suddenly turned into string cheese and the growing taste of metal in her mouth, Adora managed to clip the woman in the shoulder, causing her to cry out as her armor singed from the heat of Adora's laser blade.

"You filthy, thieving scum! It's high time you learned a little respect for the Horde."

From behind the lizard-man, Adora watched as half a dozen soldiers clambered down a makeshift ladder to form ranks, guns trained on her and Bow. "You're outnumbered, princess," the woman taunted, leveling her taser at Adora's face.

Adora heard the clamber of Bow's weapon dropping to the ground and turned to see her companion already raising his hands in defeat.

"Sorry, Adora."

Even MDA3 let out a regretful "boop."

Adora sighed and let her sword fall out of her grasp.

"Good girl." A smug smile grew on the soldier's face, similar to a maggot stretching to reach a spare piece of waste. "Foul smugglers like you need to learn to show some manners when-"

Her monologue was interrupted by the ship lurching forward. The woman tripped over the wires around her ankles and fell into the lizard-man's arms.

"Who's piloting your ship? You said this was all of you!" She picked herself out of her companion's arms with forceful anger.

"This is all of us, I swear," Adora replied.

"I thought you locked us in with your ship?" Bow questioned.

The woman's hazel eyes widened as the ship lurched again. Suddenly, the makeshift ladder began swaying in a phantom

breeze and the loud hum of an engine roared to life. Adora realized what was happening a second before the soldiers did.

Someone's hijacking their ship.

The woman began shouting orders to the soldiers who, all at once, attempted to grab onto the ladder as it bobbed up and down. The lizard-man rushed forward and bent down on one knee so the woman could climb atop his shoulders and then up the ladder, scrambling past the other soldiers with an almost inhuman speed.

Bow took advantage of the confusion to reach over and press the button that would re-seal the hatch. Adora quickly grabbed her sword as the steam began to fill the air again. She swiped her thumb across the base and felt herself shrink back down to her usual size and posture.

She heard the soldiers yelling at the woman that the fuel smugglers were getting away, but Adora ignored their cries and followed Bow down the hallway back to the cockpit.

"Can you believe our luck?" He said excitedly, flipping the manual steering switch and grabbing the reins.

"Don't jinx it- let's *go*."

"On it."

In a matter of seconds their ship was steadily gliding through the dark maw of the Gap, no docking bay alarms accosting their ears or Horde soldiers in sight. Adora didn't breathe until they got up to a solid sixty-five kilometers an hour and Bow shot her a wild grin. She couldn't help but return it.

"That was wild," he remarked.

She let out a breathy laugh. "Yeah, it was."

They fell into a comfortable silence for a few minutes as Bow prepared the ship for high-speed travel. "Never thought I'd see them again."

Adora reclined in her seat, placing one leg up and leaning her elbow against it. "You know that girl and the lizard guy?"

"No, not them specifically. The Horde."

Adora hummed in response. "You're probably going to run into them a lot more now. After... y'know."

Bow's grasp tightened on the controls. They hadn't spoken much about the death of his fiancé's mother, Queen Angella of Bright Moon, the entire journey. On one hand, Adora didn't know how to approach the subject with him, as she had spent most of the past couple months consoling Glimmer instead. On the other hand, she had a feeling that he'd needed to get away on this trip as much as she had. She wasn't going to bring up one of the reasons why it hurt so much for him to be home right now.

"Unfortunately I think you're right," he conceded. "Okay, are you ready to jump to lightspeed?"

Adora nodded. "Yep, let's go."

She braced herself for the onslaught of turbulence but when it didn't come, she looked over at Bow, confused.

He pointed at her seatbelt.

"*Krayt*, you're such a dad," she teased as she buckled herself in.

"There's nothing wrong with taking precautions," he responded firmly. "An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure."

Adora shoved his shoulder fondly.

"You too, MD," Bow added. The droid chirped as they fastened themself into the panelling near the entrance to the cockpit.

“To Krytis,” Adora instructed.

“To Krytis,” Bow repeated, flipping the switch to start Darla’s acceleration. Instead of hearing the loud groan the ship normally let out whenever they pushed her into lightspeed, Adora’s ears were met with the familiar hum of the cruising engines.

Bow flipped the switch again. Nothing.

Her companion groaned and slammed his forehead down into the controls. Adora chuckled but leaned forward to help pick him back up. “She probably just needs to be restarted,” she suggested.

While Bow concerned himself with the controls, Adora unbuckled and leaned over to check the meters that displayed Darla’s vitals. Her eyes flitted over all the gauges until one caught her eye- the red hand on the fuel gauge was all the way on EMPTY.

Adora cursed. “They siphoned our fuel.”

“Huh?”

“Those Horde bastards, they siphoned our fuel. They’re probably on our tail right now,” she stated.

“Damn,” Bow remarked, leaning back in his seat. “Maybe we can put out a distress signal and hope that someone finds us before the Horde soldiers do?”

“It’s worth a shot,” she responded, tight-lipped. If they got caught here, so close to earning enough money for the Rebellion’s upcoming offensive attack against the Horde, Adora wouldn’t know what to do with herself anymore. She had already failed at becoming the hero Light Hope wanted her to be, then failed at making a name for herself as a mercenary. She was only here - trapped aboard a run-down ship smuggling illicit goods halfway around the galaxy - because she had no other options.

She and Bow spent the remainder of the hour wiring up a distress signal on a channel that they knew the Horde wouldn’t use. Their

scanners showed no signs of the Horde ship that had tried to board them, but Adora wasn't so sure they'd completely disappeared.

After a half hour, their communications channel pinged. They both rushed to press the button to hear the incoming request.

"Hello, this is the S.S. Black Garnet. We got your distress signal, oh-two-oh-one-dash-Darla. Do you still require assistance, over."

Bow held the button down and spoke clearly as he said, "Hello, S.S. Black Garnet. We seem to have run out of fuel- specifically Phoedor. Do you have any you can spare? Over."

The channel crackled for a moment before the response came back. "Of course. Permission to dock and board? Over."

Adora sighed in relief.

"Permission granted. Thank you. Over and out," Bow finished and let out a whoop of joy.

"How lucky are we?"

"Let's just hope they're not like the last guys," she cautioned. MDA3 let out a low beep as if in agreement.

Catra flipped through the comms channels aimlessly, bored out of her mind from her fifteenth day in a row spent camped out in the space junk near Fantuth. She couldn't return empty-handed or Shadow Weaver would have her head.

Perhaps literally.

She sighed and readjusted her head in the crook of her elbow as she lay sprawled out in the cockpit of her tiny reconnaissance ship. She had outfitted it to look like a piece of space junk itself - covered in an ugly brown paint that was beginning to peel from

the nightly storms that ravaged the upper atmosphere of the ice planet.

In all honesty, she didn't know what exactly Shadow Weaver expected from her on this mission. Part of her wondered if her superior officer had just sent her out here to rot, alone in the graveyard of broken vessels and refuse from the industrialized civilization below.

As she flipped through the channels, she felt a sense of sonder overcome her: all of the voices she heard belonged to people - whether they be human or some intelligent inhuman creature - who had lives of their own, families that relied on them and whom they relied upon in turn. Hearing the overlapping languages and tongues made Catra nostalgic for the years that she held out hope that her parents would find her, that they would return and apologize for abandoning her on the doorstep of the most ruthless witch in the galaxy one rainy, winter night.

Because if they returned, Catra would finally be a part of a family again; she would love and be loved in return. Not the cruel, conditional attachment Shadow Weaver tried to pass off as affection, but *real* love.

If her parents returned, that meant that Catra was *worth* something.

Catra shook her head. It was worthless to entertain such thoughts. She had given up on ever being a part of a family or being loved a long time ago, around the time that Shadow Weaver had thrust her into space on her first mission with no money and no ship. To her officer's chagrin, she had returned two weeks later - albeit malnourished and unbathed - with the head of the politician she'd been sent to assassinate.

After that, the missions became dirtier, more despicable. If Catra ever had a soul, she lost it the moment she slit that politician's throat.

A sudden beeping noise roused her from her half-awake state. She recognized it as the emergency comms channel that she kept open for one person and one person only.

"Catra!" Scorpia's voice filled the tiny cockpit. "I need your help. Over."

Catra sighed. She raised her finger to press the button and respond, but couldn't gather the energy to go through with the motion.

"Please, Catra. I need you to bring me some extra Phoedor. Over."

Catra's finger slid against the button. "You literally just left Fantuth. How could you already be out of fuel?" She almost removed her finger before remembering proper protocol. "Over," she added.

There was a pause and then Scorpia's voice resounded through the system, somewhat garbled and staticky. "It's not for me, it's for some people we ran into. They really need our help. Over."

Catra debated the merits of leaving her post just to run a simple errand. If Shadow Weaver found out, Catra could lose her position in the witch's army. But, if she was going to run into *something* out here among the space debris, she already would have run into it. A little trip wouldn't cost her her livelihood and would allow her to finally stretch her legs, so-to-say, for the first time in over two weeks.

"Ugh, sure," she responded. "But you owe me big time. And these people better be rich. Over."

Scorpia's relieved voice came through the comms, "Oh, thank you so much, Catra! I don't know if these two have any money but I'll pay you back somehow. Sending you the coordinates now. Over."

Catra's navigation system beeped and she flicked a nail against the screen to display Scorpia's location. She was only about an hour's ride away and Catra had fuel for days stored in her cabin.

“Received. I’ll be there in a bit. Over and out.”

She hoisted herself up into a sitting position and let out a large yawn. She’d just take this little excursion then return to her post, Shadow Weaver none the wiser. After all, what was the worst thing that could happen while she was gone?

Catra flicked the switch to fire up the engines and strapped herself in. She wasn’t going to stick around to find out.

Chapter End Notes

> Thanks for tuning in! If you liked this work, let me know with kudos or comments, or come yell at me in my tumblr inbox. On your way out, check out Marie's "deep in the meadow" - a FANTASTIC she ra hunger games AU - and, if you're into Julie and the Phantoms, Mo's "Freakin' Out on the Interstate"!

Part II: Light Carries on Endlessly

Chapter Summary

> Pleasantries are exchanged, Whooloo gets a little cheeky, and Catra comes up with a plan.

Chapter Notes

> Hello! I hope you all enjoyed the first installment of this piece, it was so fun to write! There's no set posting schedule, but I'll aim for once a week. And, as a bonus, Part V and the epilogue will be posted at the same time :D Without further ado, here's Part II: Light Carries on Endlessly.

"And that's the second kitchen, but if you want to wash your hands you'll have to go to the lavatory over here."

Adora followed the tall woman, *Scorpia* as she had introduced herself, out of the kitchen and back into the main hallway of the ship. Scorpia opened the door to the lavatory again as if to remind Adora and Bow of its existence before letting out an excited chuckle.

"Any questions?"

"Uh… does your droid normally do that?" Bow inquired, pointing to the human-like droid that had crept up behind Scorpia's shoulder to wait attentively.

"I am here to attend to your needs, honored guests," the droid chimed in.

"Oh, that's just Whooloo," Scorpia waved her hand dismissively. "Our engineer, Entrapta, designed him to always follow us around in case we have an urgent need."

MDA3 rolled out from their position behind Adora's leg and beeped up at Whooloo. "Oh my! Your droid has quite the mouth!"

Whooloo protested, causing Adora to beam.

“They sure do,” she stated proudly. “Thank you again, Captain Scorpia.”

Bow echoed his thanks and the tall woman blushed. “Don’t mention it. It’s not every day that I receive a distress beacon in the middle of the Yawning Gap. You guys know there are no places to stop along the journey to Krytis, right?”

Bow nodded reluctantly. “We do. We just had a little run-in that cost us the remainder of our fuel.”

“Oh!” Scorpia exclaimed. “With who?”

He eyed Adora nervously and she jumped in. They hadn’t seen any Horde regalia in Scorpia’s ship thus far, but that didn’t mean that she and her crew weren’t aligned with the Horde in the universe’s longest and most extensive war. It was safer not to reveal which side of the war she and Bow were on, especially since it would not look great for the future King of Bright Moon to be caught smuggling illegal fuel across the galaxy in an attempt to earn enough money to finance the Rebellion’s operations.

“Just some peddlers who got upset when we didn’t want to trade,” she lied. “They siphoned our fuel before we could stop them.”

Scorpia put a hand reassuringly on Adora’s shoulder. “No need to worry. My friend will be here in no time with enough fuel to get you two all the way through the Gap.”

Adora offered what she hoped was an amicable smile in return.

“In the meantime, please make yourselves comfortable. I’m going to check on Perfuma, our amazing pilot, but I’ll be back in a pinch.”

And with that, the muscular woman disappeared down the hallway. Whooloo turned to Bow and Adora. “Can I offer you both some coffee?”

Adora shrugged. “Sure, thanks.”

She marched down the hall back towards the lounge area Scorpia had pointed out at the beginning of their tour. Bow fell into step beside her, whispering as they went, “Are you sure it’s safe for us to wait here? Maybe we should just go back down to Darla.”

Adora turned into the lounge and collapsed onto a red leather couch. She propped her feet up on a coffee table that was bolted to the floor. “We can handle ourselves if need be,” she said, patting the hilt of her sword before jerking her chin to the bow slung across her companion’s shoulder.

“So what happened with the Horde soldiers back there,” Bow began, sitting down on the loveseat opposite her. “That was ‘handling ourselves’?”

“Of course.” Adora took off her hat and rested it on her stomach.

Bow snorted disbelievingly. MDA3 rolled over to him and chirped, concerned. Bow rested his hand on the droid’s head and sank back into the cushions.

Adora followed suit, situating herself against the back of the couch and folding her hands over her hat. She felt the tug of sleep beckoning like a siren’s call. If she closed her eyes for just a moment, she knew she’d find peaceful, dreamless rest - that sweet oblivion of complete unconsciousness.

“Here are your coffees,” a robotic voice snapped Adora out of her reverie. She opened her eyes to find Whooloo standing above her with a mug in his hands. She accepted it gratefully.

“Let me know how it tastes!” a new voice chirped from behind Adora and she almost dropped the cup. She peered over Whooloo’s shoulder to see a short woman with lilac ponytails gazing eagerly at her. She gestured for Adora to take a sip and Adora complied.

“Hmm?” she intoned.

“It’s good,” Adora admitted.

“Fantastic!” the woman shouted, shocking Adora awake more than the coffee did. Adora noticed several grease stains on the woman’s overalls as she dug her fingers into one of her front pockets. She fished out a small device that she held up to her lips. “Day three hundred and twenty-two. Whooloo has successfully completed the coffee task given to him by visitors-”

She held out the device in front of Bow’s mouth. “Uh, Bow?” he offered and she nodded excitedly, racing over to hold the device near Adora’s lips.

“And Adora.”

“Bow and Adora!” the woman repeated. She pressed a button before returning the device to her pocket. “It’s lovely to meet you. I’m Entrapta, Chief Engineer of the S.S. Black Garnet.”

“Oh, you made this droid!” Bow exclaimed. “Fascinating. How did you manage to fit such an advanced computer into his shape?”

“Sir, I am flattered,” Whooloo offered and Bow’s cheeks tinted pink.

“That’s not-” he started. “I didn’t mean-”

“Oh, ignore him. His programming allows him to be a little cheeky between midnight and eight in the morning. I wasn’t expecting visitors so I forgot to turn those settings off.” Entrapta winked at Adora and she suddenly felt deeply uncomfortable.

“But his central processing unit is actually a little outdated,” she admitted. “I’m working on a newer model that combines the language processing capabilities of Whooloo with the functionality of droids like your MDA model there.”

Entrapta knelt down and looked intently at MDA3. “May I touch you?” she asked.

MDA3 responded with a short beep.

Taking their response affirmatively, Entrapta reached out and placed her hand on MDA3's head. "Oh, you're such a good droid, aren't you?"

She gave MD a final pat and stood back up. "What model processing unit does your droid have? It looks a little retrofitted."

As Bow launched into the explanation of how he salvaged MDA3 from a pile of space junk he found in his dads' garage, Adora sipped her coffee. Before long, Captain Scorpia returned to the lounge with a pretty woman with blonde hair pulled into one long braid. She pushed up some goggles from her face, revealing a smattering of freckles across her cheeks.

"Hey, Bow and Adora, this is Perfuma," Scorpia introduced.

"Hi, it's nice to meet you both," Perfuma offered in a sweet tone.

"Uh, aren't you supposed to be piloting the ship?" Bow asked, concerned.

Perfuma laughed light-heartedly. "Horde-standard auto-pilot can run for up to an hour. So we're safe for now."

Adora tried to hide the fear that crept up in her chest at the mention of the Horde. Escaping the hazel-eyed officer and the lizard-man just to run into this lot was nothing more than jumping out of the frying pan into the fire.

"Ha, of course," Bow tried. He took a sip of his coffee and an awkward silence filled the room.

"So, Adora, where'd you get that sword?" Scorpia inquired, casually placing an arm around Perfuma's waist. The pilot leaned into her touch, a soft smile growing on her face.

Adora unsheathed her sword and the room was filled with a chorus of 'ooh's and 'aah's. She didn't dare brush her thumb

against the base and risk transformation in front of all these Horde sympathizers, so she held it flat in her hands.

“My old mentor helped me craft it,” she explained. “It’s one of a kind.”

“It sure is,” Entrapta remarked.

“Can I give it a few swings?” Scorpia inquired, stepping forward with her arms outstretched.

Adora tightened her grip. “I like to keep it close.”

Scorpia returned to her position by the door. “Of course. I know we’re three strangers that you just met in one of the most remote areas of the galaxy, but we want to do whatever we can to make sure you’re comfortable.”

“Thank you all,” Bow chimed in. “Really.”

“Correction,” Whooloo’s mechanical face frowned. “The crew of the S.S. Black Garnet consists of four people, thank you very much. Entrapta didn’t design me to look like a person just for you to not refer to me as such.”

Entrapta stepped next to Whooloo and took the serving platter from him. Despite her creation towering almost a whole head taller than her, the engineer clearly held the reins concerning the droid’s acceptable social behaviour. “All right, I think it’s time we return to the lab. Catch you guys later!”

As they disappeared, a small chime rang out from Scorpia’s person. She checked a small tablet hooked to her waist and looked up excitedly and Adora and Bow.

“Catra’s almost here!” she announced. “She’s the one with the Phoedor for your ship.”

Adora downed the rest of her coffee and stood to her feet. “I’ll board her ship and help her with trying to connect to Darla if you

meet us from the other side, Bow."

Bow nodded. "Sounds like a plan."

Less than half an hour later, Adora was climbing up a makeshift ladder to one of the smallest spaceships she'd ever seen. As she'd watched it approach out of the S.S. Black Garnet's windows, she thought it nothing more than a floating piece of debris. The awful brown and black paint job wasn't doing the ship any favors either.

Scorpia had warned her that this Catra was a bit of a loner and didn't often allow people to board her ship. But Catra had taken one look at Darla and requested assistance over the comms with how to dock on "such a worthless piece of space junk," and consented to Adora boarding to help out with the fuel transfer.

Adora huffed as she reached the top of the ladder and scrambled aboard the small freighter. The interior was less appealing than the exterior, if that was even possible. It was almost completely pitch-black and devoid of warmth. Adora shivered as she turned around and took in the small cargo space, smaller processing panel, and even smaller cockpit.

"Oh good, they sent Hercules to help out."

Adora turned back around, confused as to how she could have missed someone hiding in the tiny space, when a short woman stepped out from the shadow near the cockpit. She kicked off the wall and placed her hands on her hips, appraising Adora.

Adora's first thought was that she was beautiful - all lithe limbs and angular features. She narrowed her heterochromatic eyes at Adora, revealing soft, curving eyebrows and long lashes. Even in the dim light of the ship, Adora could make out freckles adorning what seemed like every inch of her tawny skin.

Adora's second thought was that she was *deadly*. Settled neatly against the curve of her hip was a coiled whip that appeared mechanical of origin rather than leather. Strapped to the thigh

opposite the whip was a long, slender knife and peaking out from the sleeve of her dark jacket was the tip of what Adora assumed was another knife.

Who the krayt *shows up to the Yawning Gap so heavily armed?*

"You know, 'cause of your…" the woman - *Catra*, as Scorpia had said - gestured to Adora's torso.

Adora wrapped one arm around herself protectively, unsure of how to respond. The woman dropped her hand and Adora noticed a flush creep up on her cheeks.

"Whatever. What kind of bucketbrain still flies a A-300 anyways?"

"Her name is Darla," Adora responded defensively.

Catra let out a sharp laugh. "Of course it is." She turned around and sauntered over to the processing panel. Adora tried not to let her gaze linger on the sway of her hips underneath her maroon leggings.

"And from Bright Moon, no less."

Adora's heart sank. "We were just-"

Catra held up a hand even as she faced away from Adora. She flipped a couple switches on the panel before looking over her shoulder, the tips of her short brown hair brushing against the nape of her neck with the movement.

Krayt, *Adora, stay focused.*

"Relax. I won't tell Scorpia," Catra told her. "I'd hate to see someone as cute as you get locked up by those Horde bastards."

Adora gulped. "So you… you're also fighting the Horde?"

"Not exactly." She entered a code into the processing panel before gesturing for Adora to give her the pipe that she had strung

through the hatch in the floor. Adora handed it over.

“Be careful not to overload the pipe,” she cautioned. “Darla can barely handle five gallons a minute on a good day.”

“On a good day?” Catra exclaimed, incredulous. “You need a new ship.”

“What, and yours is so much better?”

“No, sweetheart. Mine’s the *best*.” Catra began walking to the back of her freighter and Adora followed. Catra screwed open the valve and Adora helped her position the heavy pipe. When the sleeves of the woman’s jacket scrunched up, Adora noticed several burn markings on her forearms. She didn’t pry, but wondered what the hell this woman had been through to earn such large scars.

When everything was situated for the transfer, Catra turned to face Adora, a devilish gleam in her eyes.

“Think you can handle this?”

Adora gripped the pipe firmly with one hand and the valve door with the other. “Do your worst, milady.”

Catra flipped a switch and Adora felt the rush of the Phoedor underneath her fingertips, the oily blood coursing through the knotty vein. She then leaned against the wall and crossed her arms, seemingly content to watch Adora attempt to keep the pipe in place. Adora tried to hide her sigh. She hoped the transfer wouldn’t take too long, as she had a feeling this lonely bandit could see right through her.

Scorpia’s latest catch is pretty easy on the eyes, Catra thought. Normally her friend picked up unpleasant, filthy vagrants who took advantage of the accommodations of the S.S. Black Garnet until Catra had to show up and forcibly kick them out.

But this girl… she was easily the most beautiful passenger that run-down ship had ever seen. Although she was dressed akin to an elderly shepherd - with a wide-brimmed hat, a red and white plaid button-up shirt tucked into gray pants, and a leather scabbard slung across her back - she radiated a sense of confidence and strength that was incredibly sexy.

And made it fun for Catra to tease her.

"So that soap you're transporting," she began, causing the blonde to look up from the fuel receptacle. "What scents do you have?"

"Almond, sandalwood, you name it."

"And you're going to sell it on Krytis?"

"Mmhmm."

"You know, I never met a Krytian who actually bathes," she remarked, turning so that her back was flush against the wall. She brought up a hand and began picking absentmindedly at her nails. "Is the soap market there bigger than the illicit fuel trade?"

To her credit, the woman didn't even blink. "I wouldn't know."

"Huh, you sure don't look like you would, sweetheart."

"The name's Adora."

"Fitting." Catra offered her a wink. "But can you imagine how ironic it would be for a, let's say, *A-300* to break down in the middle of nowhere with gallons of illegal Thulite but not even a drop of the crusty Phoedor needed to power its old-ass engines?"

Adora shot her a glare and Catra's heart soared with triumph. How Scorpia never bothered to hack into the mainframes of the ships she rescued shocked her. Catra enjoyed knowing everything about a person before she met them. Mainly for blackmail purposes.

“What do you want?” Adora grunted.

Catra’s eyes flicked down to the muscles on Adora’s arms which bulged and strained from the effort of keeping the pipe in place. “Not sure just yet.”

She sauntered over to Adora, reaching over the pipe to brush her fingertips against the tip of what seemed to be a large sword in the woman’s scabbard. “Maybe your blade, for starters.”

Adora narrowed her crystal-blue eyes. “The blade’s not up for negotiation.”

Catra withdrew her hand, her fingers brushing at some peculiar markings along the handle. She tilted her head to make out a series of lines and dots interspersed with triangles and circles.

Her blood went cold. She knew this writing, Shadow Weaver had made sure of it. What was this girl doing with a First Ones sword? And why did she seem so oddly familiar, her blonde hair and blue eyes so unlike the visages Catra ran into during her travels across the galaxy?.

Then the realization hit - this woman was *She-Ra*, the legendary warrior that Shadow Weaver and the Sisters of the Eternal Night had sworn to destroy. Though not a witch herself, Catra had sworn the same vows when she came of age - to do whatever it takes to obliterate She-Ra and the Oracles of Light Hope.

Catra couldn’t help the grin that arose on her face. Bringing home She-Ra’s head would be more than enough to escape from her indenture and finally set off on an independent voyage, beholden to nothing and no one but herself.

Adora quirked an eyebrow at the look on Catra’s face. “What is it?”

“Nothing, I just-” Catra retracted her hand and schooled her features. “I know of a buyer down on Krytis that can pay you double what you’d get selling that illicit Thulite elsewhere.”

Adora frowned as the pipe jerked. She readjusted her stance and said, "I doubt that."

"How does fifty thousand sol sound?"

The greed danced in Adora's gray-blue eyes. "Fifty thousand?"

"At the minimum," Catra responded smugly. "Let me follow you guys to Krytis and help negotiate. I promise you'll return back to Bright Moon or wherever with enough sol to fuel a hundred rebellions."

Adora hesitated. "I'll have to consult with my partner."

Catra took a step back. She didn't think she had misread the situation, but she was beginning to regret coming on so strong to this random stranger.

Not a random stranger, she reminded herself. *She-Ra*.

Adora noticed her movement and blushed. "My *business* partner, Bow. He's… we make decisions together."

Catra offered her a lop-sided smirk. "Oh, don't worry, sweetheart. I could tell he's not your type."

Adora rolled her eyes as the pump began keening, a high-pitched wail that pierced Catra's eardrums. Adora quickly readjusted the pipe and the noise stopped.

"Since you seem to know everything about me," she started. "What *is* my type, then?"

This woman made it too easy.

Catra batted her eyelashes. "Short, slender, brunette. Got a heart of steel and a penchant for throwing knives." Her fingers brushed against the top of her thigh holster instinctively. "Oh, and she just saved your ass from getting snatched up by the Horde."

Adora gave her a sincere look that stopped Catra's heart right in her chest. "Thank you."

"Don't mention it," she choked out. She cleared her throat and began walking backwards towards the hatch down to Darla. "I'll go sort things out with Scorpia. Once your tank is full, just remove the pipe and close the valve."

"And turn off the generator."

"And turn off the generator," Catra repeated. "When I get back we'll be on our way to Krytis before you can say 'Lord Hordak's Glorious Imperial Army of the Horde and All Its Related Subjects.'"

Adora let out a light chuckle that reminded Catra of a melodic, chiming bell. "Thanks again, Catra." She tipped her hat in what must be a customary salutation of her people. Catra was surprised to find that the gesture had her blushing all over again.

"Anytime, *Adora*."

Catra settled into her seat as her vessel adjusted to lightspeed. Adora's business partner, Bow, had agreed to meet Catra's black market buyer on Krytis and was now piloting his crusty-ass ship in route to Krytis behind her.

A meeting which she still needed to arrange.

She snatched the radio manual Shadow Weaver had placed in her glovebox and searched through the pages of communication codes. Luckily, she knew of a mercenary out in Krytis that the witches occasionally hired who would be able to help apprehend She-Ra and her faithful companion. She dialed the numbers into her link and waited for the beep that signaled the channels' linkage.

"Hey, it's Catra. I need you to help me with something. I've got a prize that Shadow Weaver is not gonna believe."

There was no response for a couple seconds, until Catra remembered protocol.

"*Over*."

Part III: Even After Death

Chapter Summary

The gang arrive on Krytis and meet Catra's secret buyer.

Chapter Notes

Allllllright, we got another part up! This was one of my favorites to write, I hope you all enjoy :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As Catra stepped out onto the muddy surface of Krytis, she remembered why she hated this planet the first time she had visited. Known for its gambling dens and sweatshops, Krytis was rarely frequented by anyone with morally upright intentions. Its constantly stormy weather and unbearable humidity was the cherry on top.

She wiped at the sweat already forming on the back of her neck as she shoved the last rung of the dismount ramp up into the underbelly of her ship. Luckily the ship rode low to the ground, and the ramp wasn't unbearably heavy, but Catra still wished that the buff blonde had already landed so she could complete this task for her, allowing Catra to sit back and admire the show.

As she finished, the old A-300 Adora had dubbed 'Darla' landed in the mud next to her.

Catra held up a hand to prevent mud from flying up onto her face, but unfortunately the rest of her wasn't so lucky. As she shook the mud from her clothes, she chortled to herself.

And Adora had the gall to try and pretend she was transporting soap *to Krytis.*

Despite the woman's horrible forgery skills - and the fact that she was secretly an elite warrior Catra had pledged her life to destroy

- Catra found that she couldn't stop thinking about her beautiful, wide eyes and cute laugh the entire ride over here.

Get a grip, Catra. You can't develop a crush on the woman you're about to lead into a deadly trap.

She checked her comms device, but found no new messages from her contact. She wasn't all that worried. Double Trouble had never failed on a mission before, making them one of the most sought-after mercenaries on this side of the Donurn Belt.

A ramp extended from Darla's underbelly, followed by Adora and the man that Catra had spoken to over the comms earlier - Bow. He was dressed in a light pink raincoat that blew open in the breeze to reveal a white and gold tank top and navy pants. A small, rotund droid with several crooked arms extending from their midsection rolled around the two humans and into the mud. They let out several jubilant beeps.

"I know, MD," Adora said as she reached the bottom of the ramp. "Your favorite."

"Your droid likes mud?" Catra inquired, disbelieving. The droid emitted a series of high-pitched 'boop's before rolling through the mud to rest behind Adora's leg.

"Rain." Bow explained. "They don't see much of it back home. Thanks again for arranging this meeting on such short notice."

"Anytime. I presume Adora's told you about my cut?"

"We agreed on 3,000 sol," Adora jumped in.

"5,000," she countered.

Adora reached up and readjusted her hat before squaring her shoulders and facing Catra. "3,500, milady."

The price didn't really matter, as Adora and Bow would be long gone before Catra stole their ship and sold their fuel on the black

market, but she couldn't let them think they were getting away that easily.

"Four grand," Catra rested a hand on her hip as the rain began to pick up. "Final offer."

Adora and Bow exchanged a look. "Deal," Bow agreed.

"Fantastic. Now let's get out of this gods-forsaken rain. My contact said they'll meet us at the Enchanted Grotto and that's all the way across town."

With that, the three of them scurried out of the docking lot and down a narrow passageway framed by short, decrepit structures, the circular droid in tow. Although the clock had yet to strike midday, throngs of people crowded the dark streets, their presence only enhancing the muggy atmosphere. Underneath the neon letterings and glowing signs, Catra, Bow, and Adora passed a ship repair shop operated by a spindly humanoid with four arms, a chemist who brazenly boasted their illegal spice prices, and several working-class restaurants that served heaps of melted ration bars in troughs.

Catra noticed Adora's gaze linger on the troughs. She opened her mouth to remark on the primitive manner in which a blue-skinned man shoved his face down into the food when she realized it was *hunger* gleaming in Adora's eyes, not disgust.

Well I'll be damned if this beautiful woman doesn't get a proper last meal.

"C'mon," Catra said over the noise of the streets. "This way."

Adora, Bow, and their droid followed as Catra pushed past an obnoxious creature with a high-pitched garble trying to sell them jewelry. She led them down a long alley, careful to step over the people passed out in the mud.

When they finally emerged, they found themselves in a somewhat nicer area of town- all reinforced windows and concrete flower

boxes.

“Is it always this dark?” Bow questioned.

Catra looked up at the ferocious storm clouds that blanketed the city in an eternally sluggish haze. “Pretty much,” she responded.

“All day long?”

“For the most part.” She stopped outside of a set of double doors, their dented steel exterior painted a deep olive. “Hence why the locals have made accommodations.”

She wrenched open the door and gestured for her companions to enter. She watched as a muted awe lit up Adora’s soft features.

“Oh, wow,” she remarked. She turned around to flash Catra a shy smile, her crooked grin forming the most adorable dimple in her right cheek.

Something warm stirred deep in the cockles of Catra’s frozen heart- an overwhelming desire to do whatever it took to see the girl’s crystal eyes sparkle joyously like that again.

She pushed away the fleeting notion and entered the indoor market. Unlike the slums near the docking lot, these vendors advertised high-quality fruits and vegetables, jewelry and clothing, accessories and technology.

“Mother of moons!” Bow exclaimed in his slightly twangy accent. “Is that genuine Orrot titanium?”

Without waiting for a response, he took off towards a tall vendor with a display of metallic sheets organized by color and price. The little droid raced after him, almost tripping several patrons who had to jump out of their way.

“Here,” Catra brushed her fingertips against Adora’s arm and the girl’s head snapped over to her faster than a cedar tree struck by lightning. “I bet you’ve never tried ginger beetles before.”

She couldn’t help the laugh that escaped from deep within her at the apprehensive look on Adora’s face. “They’re not actually be-“ She stopped to dodge a pudgy man drunkenly waving his arms about as he talked to his companion, a well-dressed fellow in a top hat and glasses. At the end of the drunken man’s statement, the well-dressed man let out a loud burp, causing him to hide his face in his hands and his companion to clap him on the back.

“Just trust me- you’ll love ‘em,” Catra stated.

“Lead the way, space bandit.”

Catra rolled her eyes so hard she was afraid she’d get whiplash. “Your nicknaming skills need improvement, sweetheart.”

“Guess I’ll have to learn from the best, huh?”

Catra felt her cheeks heat up at the insinuation and turned so Adora couldn’t see how easily she got underneath her tough exterior. She quickly found a vendor selling ginger beetles and purchased two (very overpriced) bags. Adora raised her hand to her hat and tipped it as they were leaving, causing the woman to offer up a mirthful smile. Catra practically yanked Adora away by the arm.

They quickly settled on a nearby bench and Catra watched intently as Adora took her first bite.

“Oh!” She exclaimed. “They’re... it’s...”

“Espresso laced with ginger-flavored protein powder. They’ll keep you full for a while,” Catra explained.

Adora nodded solemnly before digging her hand into the bag and stuffing several beetles into her mouth. Catra munched on hers half-heartedly, all her attention orbiting around this skilled warrior masquerading as an illegal fuel smuggler.

“I’m guessing you’ve never been to Krytis before?”

Adora didn't stop chewing as she responded. "Uh, no, actually. What makes you say that?"

Catra scoffed. "If you'd been here before you would've tried these."

"Not necessarily. Just because you haven't tried one local delicacy doesn't mean you've never visited that city." She flipped the bag upside down and dumped the remainder of its contents into her mouth. "Or that planet," she added through a mouthful of beetles.

"You're telling me that when you go to Shesir you don't eat the monkey brains? Or when you visit Chari in the summer you *don't* try the frozen rum?"

Adora offered her a sheepish look. "I've never actually been to Shesir. Or Chari."

Catra reeled back in surprise.

"I had a pretty sheltered upbringing," Adora explained. "I've actually only ever been to three planets. Unless you count the one I was born on, but I don't remember that."

Cloistered childhood. Obscure origins. Catra was all too familiar with both of those. Maybe the two of them were more alike than she realized.

She didn't let her reaction show. "*Krayt*, only three planets?"

Adora folded up her bag and stared at it mournfully. "Trust me, I would have traveled if I could."

"What's stopping you now?" Catra questioned in a soft voice. The commotion of the marketplace around them seemed to fade into a distant hum.

"For one, *money*."

“You’re about to be rich, though,” she pressed. “One half of forty-five thousand-”

“Forty-six thousand,” Adora corrected.

Catra winked at her. “I can’t get anything past you, sweetheart.”

Adora gave her a pointed look.

“As I was saying, one half of forty-six thousand is no small sum.”

“Well, that money’s not going to me,” Adora explained. She rubbed at the back of her neck and Catra realized that she must be debating whether or not to open up to her about her work for Bright Moon. Little did she know that Catra was already fully aware of who she was and the role she played in the Rebellion.

To spare Adora the effort of explaining anything, Catra shifted closer. “When do you get some of that money? When do you get to do what *Adora* wants to do?” Catra punctuated her sentence by poking the other girl in the cheek.

Adora shrugged. She didn’t seem to mind the physical contact so Catra allowed her hand to fall loosely around the other girl’s elbow. “When the war is over, I guess.”

“This war’s been going on for hundreds of years and will probably continue long after we’re dead,” Catra snidely remarked. “If you don’t make time to live for yourself now, you never will.”

Adora turned to face her and Catra’s breath caught in her throat as she realized just how close they had gotten. The blonde raised an eyebrow at her, issuing a silent challenge.

Catra’s head spun. As much as she longed to take her own advice, Shadow Weaver would literally kill her if she found out how close Catra had come to taking out She-Ra only to be seduced by the allure of sparkling blue eyes and sweetly curved lips.

She pulled away, the noise of the marketplace suddenly crescendoing into a cacophonous roar. Catra turned to see a loud group of Shesiri tourists stumble through the back door, their ruby exoskeletons glistening from the rain. Even though she couldn't understand a word of what they were saying, she could tell they were complaining about the weather as they vigorously shook themselves dry.

Through the bustling crowd, she spotted Bow and the droid making their way over to the bench. Catra sighed. "Looks like it's time to go."

Adora followed her gaze and waved jauntily at her *business partner*. As the two of them stood, Catra tossed her bag of leftover beetles to Adora. The woman's eyes widened, like somebody had just given her a million sol.

"Are you sure?" she questioned.

"Yeah," Catra said. "Maybe this'll convince you that traveling and seeing other planets is worth your time."

"Thank you, milady," Adora replied, as genuine as the last time she had uttered those words aboard Catra's ship. Once again, Catra was dumbstruck by her sincerity.

"You know, when Scorpia said her 'lonely pirate friend' wanted to help us out, I was a little doubtful. But you're a lot nicer than you give yourself credit for," Adora complimented.

"That's just part of the act, darlin'," Catra replied honestly. Once Bow was within hearing range, she jerked her chin back towards the entrance. "Let's go. Double Trouble doesn't like to be kept waiting."

Adora couldn't recall the last time she was overwhelmed by the odor of writhing, sweaty bodies squeezed into an underground illegal bot fighting arena, but after half an hour in the Enchanted

Grotto she swore she'd never get stuck somewhere like that again.

The musky air provided a damp curtain to separate the bystanders from the competitors, although people were sticking their fingers and arms through the large gaps in the steel cage to probe the robot fighters. The sight of such cruel treatment of droids made Bow turn around and send MDA3 back to the ship.

"Maybe if we leave now we can still make our original appointment," Bow whispered in her ear once he returned.

Adora shifted from where she stood up on one of the eight balconies overlooking the arena. She hadn't dared to watch much of the match after one of the droids outfitted with an axe for an arm went haywire and cut off several onlookers' fingers.

"Fifty thousand sol, Bow," she responded. "We just need to hang in here for a little longer and then we'll have fifty *thousand* sol."

"Forty-four thousand," Catra hissed in her other ear and Adora started. She hadn't realized the bandit had been listening.

"Forty-six," Adora pushed back. "And when the *krayt* is your contact going to show up?"

Catra scanned the room. "They're here, they just don't like to talk shop until after a few rounds." She pointed up to a balcony shrouded in shadow on the floor above theirs. "And for your sake, you better hope those rounds were entertaining or they might not be in such a generous mood."

Adora folded her arms over her chest and glared at the back of the head in front of her until Catra finally grabbed her shoulder. "Okay, they're ready."

Adora looked over at Bow and he gave her a reassuring nod. "Let's do this."

They followed Catra up a set of stairs that smelled strongly of excrements of all varieties. Upon reaching the top they were greeted by a muscular woman with a high ponytail that swished behind her as she crossed her arms.

"Do you have an appointment?" She appraised the three of them with a haughty sneer.

"Yes," Catra snidely remarked.. "But even if we didn't-" She stood up on her tippy toes to peer over the woman's shoulder. "-I would hope they would make an exception for an old friend."

A loud cheer rang up from the crowd below followed by the clanging of a bell that signalled the end of a bot fight. Once the clamor died down, Adora heard a low chuckle emanating from the third floor balcony.

"Let them in, Huntara," a voice called out.

Although she looked like she'd prefer to do quite the opposite, the buff woman stepped aside and gestured for them to enter the loge.

Adora climbed up a small set of three stairs before she could see the large private viewing box adorned with lavish decorations- flowing emerald curtains, plush leather upholstery; even a large glass liquor cabinet sat against the far wall.

Lounging on the loveseat closest to the railing was a green-skinned lizard-person who blinked up at them with yellow parietal eyes.

"Ah, what has the cat dragged in this time?" they ruminated in a lengthy draw.

Catra's shoulders tensed at the words. Whatever history she had with this 'old friend' didn't seem to be quite so friendly.

Less than a second later, she visibly relaxed and put on a confident smile. Her transition was so smooth that Adora

wondered if she had made the whole thing up in her own head. “Adora, Bow - meet Double Trouble. They’re a purveyor of luxury goods like your Thulite.”

Double Trouble sat up from their reclined position but made no move to greet them any further. Adora kept her hand clutched around the strap of her leather scabbard, wary of the lizard-person’s seemingly cavalier attitude.

“It’s wonderful to meet you,” Bow started. “We’re looking to sell about two hundred thousand gallons of some of the nicest Thulite around. We were told you could help?”

“Perhaps,” they drawed, rapping their knuckles against their cheek. “But first, entertain me: how did you obtain such high-quality Thulite? Forgive me, but you two don’t strike me as quite the thieves.”

That was a story Adora had no interest in sharing and luckily Bow kept it vague, “Well you can’t get milk without eating grass.”

The lizard-person tilted their head at him for a moment before bursting out in howling laughter. They pointed at Bow but spoke to Catra, “I like this one.”

“He’s alright,” she conceded. “I told them you could spare about fifty thousand sol, DT.”

The laughter stopped at the mention of the price. “I’ll have to check out the fuel first. If I’m going to be dropping such a large sum, I’d like to inspect the quality of my investment first-hand.”

“We can show you any proof you desire,” Adora complied. “So long as you give us five thousand sol right here, right now.”

Double Trouble finally stood up and brushed invisible dust off of their elaborate teal and gold outfit. They paced over to Adora and stared up at her, unblinking. Adora remained resolute in her returning gaze.

Eventually their eyes shifted down to the tip of her sword handle that was peeking out from behind her shoulder. “I like this one too. You have a deal." They looked over at Catra and crooned, “Oh, cash kitten!”

Catra groaned and fished out a handful of sol from a pocket sewn into the lining of her leather jacket. She handed the money over to Adora, who counted five one-thousand sol chips.

“Why-” she started to ask but Catra waved her question away. “Don’t worry, DT and I have a combined interest in ensuring that this sale occurs. Should we go back to your ship?”

Despite Catra’s calm exterior, Adora sensed a stream of anxiety rippling beneath her skin. Were people always this nervous during exchanges of such high value?

Moreover, why did Catra front the money for Double Trouble when she too was hoping to make a profit from this trade? Something was off about the situation, but Adora couldn’t tell what exactly it was just yet.

She resolved to keep her eyes peeled and her hand within easy grabbing distance of her sword in case things went awry.

“Sure, lead the way.”

They all exited the bot fighting arena via a back staircase that Double Trouble obviously had reserved only for themself and their clients. The rain had let up slightly, but Adora still felt her hat slowly sink lower and lower onto her head, the fabric weighed down by the moisture. When they arrived back at the lot, Bow pressed the button on his tablet to call for MDA3 to open the dismount hatch.

The droid didn’t respond.

Adora leaned over and tried pressing it herself. Still no response. Double Trouble, who was standing under an umbrella Huntara the

bodyguard held above their head, looked unamused. Catra gave Adora a gesture that obviously meant 'hurry up.'

Adora huffed and walked over to the belly of the ship. She climbed up the landing gear to manually release the dismount hatch before jumping out of the way so the ramp could extend down into the mud.

"We have most of the containers in the cargo hold," she told Double Trouble as they all climbed aboard. "Feel free to open any that you'd like- I trust you'll find that they're all up to snuff."

Bow slid open the first door to the airlock and gestured for everyone to enter.

"I'll be the judge of that," Double Trouble replied with a toothy grin.

Adora tried to hide her annoyance as she marched over to open the second airlock door. As soon as she stepped into the cargo hold, a pair of large hands grabbed her waist and tossed her effortlessly into the wall. She stumbled to her feet to find several figures staring down at her, all with the same white ponytails as Huntara.

Adora whipped out her sword and slid her thumb along the scanner. Even before her transformation was complete, she began swinging at the intruders, letting out a throaty cry as she sliced into one of their shoulders. She heard Bow and Catra struggling with Huntara back in the airlock, and Adora knew she needed to do something to help them escape.

She glanced down briefly at the control panel near the airlock door. She just needed to get past these four beefy individuals - all of whom thrust their long spears into the air and let out a joint war cry - and unlock the second airlock door so Bow and Catra could escape.

Adora lifted her sword and grinned. *Some trouble indeed.*

She allowed her training to take over as she dodged a blow from one of the intruders and used the momentum to push herself into the air and kick the heads of the two in the back. She rolled off of her attacker's shoulder and parried a blow from the fourth intruder. He let out a vicious growl before spitting in her face.

Adora slammed her elbow up into his chin as she dodged another blow from the first intruder. Although she was outnumbered by what seemed to be well-trained mercenaries, she was confident she could take them.

She was *She-Ra*, after all.

She jumped back to avoid the pointed tip of one of their spears before she felt something prick the back of her neck. She reached back and pulled a small pink dart out of her skin. Immediately, her vision started to blur and someone kicked the Sword of Protection out of her hand.

Her knees hit the ground first, the dull clang of her golden armor against the metallic grates below, before the intruders slammed her head to the ground and tied her hands behind her back. Without her sword, she became just Adora again- no armor, no magic.

When they released her head, she blinked up at the rough outline of a green face with piercing yellow eyes.

"That was almost too easy, wasn't it, kitten?" Double Trouble remarked.

Huntara dropped Bow unceremoniously on the floor next to her. He also had his hands tied behind his back and gave her a confused look. She looked over her shoulder to see where they were keeping Catra but found the airlock empty.

She turned back around only to find herself face-to-face with Catra's mechanical whip jangling from her belt. Confused, Adora looked up to see Catra standing above her, a satisfied grin upon her face.

"I think I'll be taking this back now, darlin'," she said and reached into Adora's pocket for the sol chips.

Although attempting to form a coherent thought felt like swimming through a pool of pudding, Adora could piece together enough of what happened to realize that Catra had tricked them. The shock of her betrayal rippled through Adora's body like an earthquake.

"But you were going to get part of our cut." Her tongue felt like sandpaper in her mouth. "You haggled with me. Repeatedly."

Catra leaned down and poked her in the cheek again. "Like I said before, that was just part of the act." She stood back up but Adora's head was too tired to follow her movement.

"You can do whatever you want with the archer. She-Ra is mine," she heard Catra say.

At the mention of her name, Adora felt another earthquake ripple through her veins. *Catra knew. She knew all along.*

Adora clenched her jaw so hard she tasted blood. She had been duped, but she sure as *krayt* wasn't going to let this cunning bandit get away with it.

As the mercenaries moved to pick up Bow, Adora closed her eyes and summoned the energy buried deep within her bones and in between her teeth. She *was* She-Ra, Princess of Power, with or without the Sword of Protection. As Light Hope had instructed, she drew upon the well of power within her being and thrust her hands out, snapping the ties around her wrists. A wave of iridescent magic emerged in midair and consumed the mercenaries, knocking them flat on the ground.

She stood - every inch of her thrumming with power - and summoned the wave back to her, knocking over Double Trouble, Huntara, and Catra this time.

But just as quickly as the magic came, it dissipated, leaving Adora shaking and woozy. She collapsed to the ground again just as the mercenaries stood back up. She tried to reconnect with her power, but her head was too jumbled and her senses too distorted.

From somewhere in the distance, she heard a loud crash. The ship teetered to the side and Adora grabbed onto the grates in the floor to keep her balance. The mercenaries suddenly let out another war cry and Adora looked up to see a flying purple and pink blur appear behind their heads.

"Step! Away! From! My! Fiancé!"

Adora swore she was dreaming as one of her best friends, Queen Glimmer Bright Moon, swung her revolvers around in her hands and fired at the mercenaries. Blasts of white light bubbled in the air with each pull of the triggers, a wild grin upon Glimmer's face before she disappeared and reappeared in front of Bow and Adora, guns pointed at the intruders.

Huntara grabbed Double Trouble and escaped into the airlock, closing the door firmly behind them. The mercenaries raised their spears as Catra released her whip from its holster and slung it through the air towards one of Glimmer's guns. Glimmer dodged easily.

"What type of ammo is that? Sparkles?" Catra taunted.

"Laser bullets, bitch. And they bite." Glimmer wasted no more time with pleasantries as she charged forward and attacked all five people at once. Adora lunged for her Sword, rejoicing in the pleasant rush of power that came from being reunited with her precious weapon. She was unsteady on her feet as she stood and swung at the person who happened to be closest to her - *Catra*.

"Why did you do this?" she cried out as she swung at Catra's whip hand. The other girl had one of her long knives in Adora's face before she could blink. Adora was forced to retract her sword to parry the blow.

“Why does it matter to you?” Catra responded, grunting from the force of Adora’s blade against her own.

Adora pushed back, the force of it almost causing her to lose her already unsteady balance. They needed to get out of here, *fast*.

Out of the corner of her eye she noticed Bow retching from the effort of fighting off whatever poison had been in those darts. When one of Glimmer’s laser blasts ricocheted off of the walls of the cargo hold, he called out, “Careful, Glimmer! The Thulite.”

Adora cursed under her breath as she jumped up to prevent Catra’s whip from tripping her. If one laser blast hit those fuel containers, the entire ship would go up in a blaze that town would never forget.

An idea suddenly struck her.

She dodged out of Catra’s reach and scooped up Bow. Stepping behind Glimmer, she drew the tip of her blade into the grates beneath them, channeling all of her remaining energy into branding a scolding seam onto the floor of the ship. Glimmer let out a startled cry as the grates beneath them melted and they fell twenty feet into the mud below.

Once she had picked herself up out of the mud, she turned to Glimmer. “Where’s your ship?”

Glimmer spat a piece of grass out of her mouth. “Over there!” She exclaimed, pointing to a bulky cargo freighter painted a deep magenta.

Adora and Glimmer helped Bow to his feet and ran as fast as they could towards the ship. Adora heard a series of beeps resound and suddenly MDA3 rolled out in front of her, their mechanical arms whirring in a wild fury.

“MD?!”

The droid continued their tirade of high-pitched noises but Adora's brain was still too muddled to comprehend what they were saying. A spear flew over her shoulder, prompting her to grit her teeth and push herself even faster.

Glimmer had left the ramp down, so they quickly scurried up into the ship. Adora made sure Bow was safely situated into one of the seats behind the cockpit before she settled into the passenger seat. As Glimmer powered up the engines, Adora peered out the front window.

The four people with spears had congregated by the base of the ship with Huntara and Double Trouble, the latter of whom pointed upwards as they said something emphatically to the group. One of the white-haired individuals leapt forward and placed a small device on the underbelly of the ship. Adora immediately recognized it as a timed explosive device, quite similar to the models the Rebellion used to blow up Horde transports.

Adora leaned forward in her seat and squinted, re-counting the number of people standing outside the ship. *Where's Catra?*

That's when Adora noticed a flash of black and red through the cockpit window of her ship. Catra settled into the pilot's seat and caught Adora's gaze, giving her a rude hand gesture.

She doesn't know about the bomb.

Adora unbuckled herself and jumped from her seat.

"Adora? What are you doing?" Glimmer protested.

"Unlock the dismount hatch!" She called out in response. "And prepare to get the hell out of here as soon as I get back."

Luckily, Glimmer trusted her enough to open the dismount hatch without further objection. Adora vaulted through the hole in the ship, unwilling to waste any precious time waiting on the ramp. She didn't even think as she *sprinted* towards Darla. If she thought, she might rationalize that it was useless to attempt to

save Catra, since the bandit had proved herself to care little for Adora's well-being.

Double Trouble and their group were fleeing towards another ship already hovering in the air as Adora approached. Upon closer inspection, the explosive device stuck like a star barnacle to the underbelly of her ship was the exact model the Rebellion frequently utilized.

I guess Double Trouble trades with both parties in the war.

Adora, still as She-Ra, jumped the twenty feet directly up into the ship. She knew there was no way to stop the bomb from going off, as it was solely remote-controlled, so she had to get Catra as far away from the ship *as soon as possible.*

She clambered past the wreckage of their fight and sprinted towards the cockpit. Upon her arrival, Catra whirled around and frowned. She reached for her whip, but Adora leapt forward and tackled her, concentrating her magic out in an arc in front of them to blast through the reinforced glass. Catra struggled in her arms as they fell, but Adora held on tight, angling them so that her back hit the ground first.

Despite the copious amounts of mud, the impact of slamming against the unyielding ground knocked the wind right out of her. Catra scrambled to her feet, relatively unscathed save for several scratches on her arms and stomach from the shattered glass.

"What the *krayt* are you doing, Adora?"

"Bomb-" she gasped. "Get out of here."

With one look above them, Catra's gaze darkened. "You chose to save me. I don't owe you anything." And with that, she sprinted for her original ship, all hopes of escaping with the gallons of Thulite gone.

Adora tried to stand, but her leg twisted painfully underneath her. She vaguely registered Glimmer lowering a platform down and

one of MDA3's long appendages scooping her up as they sped away from the city. She was still hanging from the droid's arm as a dark mushroom cloud bloomed over the horizon.

She watched the explosion bury the city in a cataclysmic coffin until she could keep her eyes open no longer, and promptly passed out.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all for continuing to read and support this story! All of your comments have made me super happy, I hope you guys stay tuned for the final two parts (+ epilogue!)

Part IV: With Shortness of Breath, Explain the Infinite

Chapter Summary

> Catra receives updated orders from Shadow Weaver while Adora ponders her destiny. With a little help from the galaxy's greatest matchmaker (Entrapta obviously), the two begin to hurtle towards their inevitable, and likely fatal, showdown.

Chapter Notes

> Trigger Warning: Abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You insolent little bitch!"

The back of Shadow Weaver's hand hit Catra's cheek this time, splitting open one of the larger cuts she'd received from tumbling face-first through the glass and landing unceremoniously in the mud next to her mortal enemy.

Mortal enemy who saved *you*, she reminded herself.

Catra didn't dare recall Adora's reckless compassion lest it provide a sliver of hope to her desolate moor. Shadow Weaver could sniff out any fanciful aspirations faster than a bloodhound, and make you forget about them even quicker.

When the next blow didn't come, Catra picked herself off the obsidian floor. For the self-proclaimed Sisters of the Eternal Night, Shadow Weaver and her dark witches really leaned into the 'night' element when constructing their insidious fortress. The walls, the bastion, the main structure: everything was crafted of the purest obsidian, its onyx appearance marred only by flecks of glittering purple magic.

She supposed the rock was fitting - as streams of lava pulsed underneath their feet to feed the lifeblood of the planet: a grand and imposing volcano - but the obsidian watchtower seemed a little ostentatious for a military base.

Besides, lightning always struck the tall tower whenever it stormed, likely due to some draw of the immense magical power contained within. Catra didn't even try to understand it, as she had not even a drop of supernatural power in her blood, a fact that Shadow Weaver often liked to mention whenever she failed in her duties.

"I gave you one simple task," Shadow Weaver growled from behind her ruby mask. "How is it you return empty-handed?"

Catra dared a glance at the guards lining the walls. Each armor-clad witch stood to attention underneath the sloping beams rising towards the vaulted ceiling. She knew she couldn't rely on them for any pity, as they had remained silent for almost twenty years as Shadow Weaver shamed, catechized, and abused Catra.

"Answer me, child. How did you let She-Ra escape?" Shadow Weaver's voice boomed throughout the cavernous chamber.

Catra's fingers flicked down unconsciously to her whip. She wouldn't ever use it on Shadow Weaver, but its presence reminded her that she wasn't completely helpless.

"She had assistance. Some Rebel soldiers came and rescued her."

Despite the mask, Catra could tell Shadow Weaver was unimpressed by her response. She was immediately glad that she had lied about the number of rescuers, as hearing that just one girl with two sparkly guns thwarted Catra would likely send Shadow Weaver into anaphylactic shock.

"Have I not trained you to exploit every Rebel's weakness? Destroy every soldier who dares cross your path?" Shadow Weaver sighed and marched back towards the expansive, circular pool of lava in the middle of the room. Catra obediently followed.

“I took you in when your own parents didn’t even wish to care for you and this is how you repay me?” She moved both of her arms in a smooth wave and a stream of lava sprang up from the pool to hover in the air.

Catra winced in anticipation and began to shed her jacket so Shadow Weaver could inflict more burns upon the already scarred and twisted flesh of her forearms.

“You ungrateful maggot!” She screeched, hurtling the lava towards Catra. Catra closed her eyes and attempted to steady her breathing, but panic bubbled up in her chest. She felt the scalding heat of the lava approach and then halt.

She peeked open an eye. Shadow Weaver moved her arms in the opposite motion and the lava fell back into the pool. “Let me be clear. If you do not bring me She-Ra’s decimated corpse in two weeks time, I will cut off your filthy head and string your innards from the gates of the bastion,” she growled. “And if you get any ideas about bailing on your mission, I will cash in your debt to me early and send the Reaper for you.”

Catra swallowed nervously and glanced down at the pool of lava. Underneath the surface, thousands of tortured souls blinked up at her, all of them contorted in some sort of eternal pain.

A fate worse than death, Shadow Weaver had told her when Catra pledged her life to the Sisters.

Catra would much rather have her innards strung up on the bastion than spend the remainder of time and space drowning in Shadow Weaver’s fiery pit of despair.

“Do you understand, child?”

There was no hesitation when Catra responded, “Yes, Shadow Weaver.”

Adora let her spoon clank against the bottom of the bowl as she leaned back in her chair and rubbed her full stomach. Glimmer turned her watchful gaze from the field reports in front of her to the bowl.

"Adora…" she warned.

Adora huffed. "I already ate three-fourths of it. Do I really have to finish?"

Glimmer frowned, the morning sunlight streaming through the stained glass window behind her to crown her with a multicolored halo. "This is the most I've seen you eat since you've been back at Bright Moon, and normally you would've called for seconds by now."

Glimmer was correct- Adora was notorious for eating up a feast each time she was in between assignments and stayed at Bright Moon Castle.

Of course, 'castle' was a misnomer, as the Rebellion's Headquarters took up almost the entire moon. Full of curving corridors and iridescent inclines, the fortress was always bustling with activity. As General Juliet often said: the war never sleeps, so neither does Bright Moon.

Ever since her mother, Queen Angella, heroically sacrificed herself to save an entire fleet of refugees seeking shelter with the Rebellion, Glimmer had assumed all of the major responsibilities of leading an enormous galactic army. Under her command, the Rebellion was inching closer and closer to ultimate victory over the Horde, but they were draining themselves of funds along the way.

Adora pushed the bowl away from her. "I'm not-"

"Don't you dare say you're not hungry," Glimmer turned to her. "You're still She-Ra, Princesses of Power and loyal soldier to the Rebellion, right?"

Adora nodded mutely.

“Then as your commanding officer I order you to finish that porridge.”

Defeated, Adora picked the spoon up again and managed to swallow another bite of the milky oats. The poison from those darts, combined with the effort of their daring escape, had completely knackered her. Today was the first day she had been able to clamber out of bed before noon.

But she needed to regain her strength. The Rebellion was slowly going broke and she was set to embark on a mission tomorrow as part of a last-ditch effort to sell several hundred electronic tablets on the black market in Salineas.

Deep down she knew that the Rebellion hadn’t recruited her just so she could play smuggler. Her ultimate role in the Rebellion’s quest for justice would be much more extensive, and much more fatal.

She sighed and quickly scooped up the remaining porridge. Her mouth still half-full, she turned to Glimmer. “I’ve been thinking about that, actually.”

Glimmer peered up from the papers in front of her, eyes glassy and mind clearly a thousand miles from home. “Hmm, Salineas?”

“No, She-Ra,” she clarified. “And everything with Light Hope’s prophecy. She said that once I was able to transform into She-Ra without the Sword, the ‘haunting hounds of destiny would come yapping at my heels’ or something like that.”

Glimmer waved her hand dismissively. “Are you really going to listen to that old hag? Didn’t she tell you that you were allergic to sugar so you wouldn’t eat the cookies Mara baked?”

At the mention of the kindest witch among the Oracles, Adora’s heart blossomed. Mara, who was at least ten years older than Adora, had taken pity on her during their training. Although she

died from a sudden shipwreck, Adora could still recall Mara's dazzling smile and airy laugh.

“Yes, but this is a little more serious than cookie consumption.”

Glimmer fixed her with a hard stare. “Nothing is more serious than cookie consumption.”

Adora laughed for what felt like the first time in forever. Glimmer reached over and placed a hand on Adora’s forearm. “Don’t worry about the prophecy. Whatever comes our way, you’ll be able to handle it- not as She-Ra, but *Adora*. You’re stronger than you know.”

“Thanks, Glim,” she replied. The Queen returned to her paperwork and Adora to her porridge. The room was silent for about five seconds before Adora continued, “Your mom believed in Light Hope’s prophecy.”

“Yeah, well I’m not my mom, am I?” Glimmer snapped.

Adora silently ate her last bite as Glimmer stared at the opposite wall. “Sorry, Adora, it’s just-“ she hesitated, obviously seeking out the best words to describe her situation. “It’s been *hard* trying to run the Rebellion without her. And with you and Bow gone all the time on missions, sometimes I just feel so alone.”

Adora fought her aching limbs and stood up to march over to Glimmer’s chair. She wrapped her best friend in a hug. “I’m right here.”

Glimmer sniffled and wrapped her arms around Adora even tighter. As Adora was pulling away, the door creaked open as Bow marched in.

“Aw, did I miss a signature Best Friends Squad Hug?” He implored.

Adora allowed herself to be wrapped in another hug, Bow’s smiling face squished up next to hers. She moved to gather her

bowl and return it to the kitchens when Bow said, "Hey, Adora, we need to talk."

She didn't fail to notice the look he and Glimmer shared as she whirled around. "About what?"

Bow gestured for her to sit down. When she complied, he reached into the lining of his bomber jacket and pulled out a tablet. He slid it across the table to her.

"I did some research on Catra."

Adora's heart sank. *This can't be good news.*

"Turns out she's a wanted criminal on over 46 planets and in over 2,000 municipalities- all for murder." Bow hesitated, trying to hide a wince before he continued, "She's an assassin of the Sisters of the Eternal Night."

Adora felt the floor lurch out from underneath her. Talk of the Sisters and the Oracles in the same day only served to feed the growing dread within her.

"*One day you will stop trying to escape your destiny*," Light Hope had told her the night before she ran away. "*Fate has a ruthless prowl, and you wish not to be unprepared when she pounces to claim you for her own*."

Adora was so swept up in matters of She-Ra and destiny that she almost missed what Bow said about Catra. *An assassin*. Honestly, that didn't surprise her. The way that Catra gracefully maneuvered them through the crowds in Krytis and the surprising precision with which she attacked Adora on the ship were clearly skills she had cultivated during her time with the Sisters.

Adora felt her stomach twist as a thought struck her: *Had Catra been sent to the Yawning Gap to kill* me*?*

On the outside, she feigned nonchalance. "Okay, so? Why are you acting like this is the end of the world?"

Bow eyed her curiously. “You risked your life, you risked *our* lives, to go back for the person who clearly scammed and betrayed us. You’re telling me that finding out she’s a sworn member of the evil conclave of witches dedicated to destroying She-Ra means nothing to you?”

She shrugged. “Yes?”

Bow’s face fell into his hands and Glimmer took over. “What Bow is trying to say is that you owe us an explanation. Why did you save her from the bomb?”

Adora stared up at the stained glass behind Glimmer. The soft blues of the forget-me-nots carved into the glass reflected onto the floor below, creating the mirage of a flowery pool. “I couldn’t just let her die. Assassin, smuggler, traitor - it doesn’t matter; she doesn’t deserve to get blown up for it.”

The room fell into a tense silence before Glimmer spoke back up, “You know what I find odd? She could’ve killed you at any point during your trip, but she didn’t.”

For some unknown reason, Adora felt hope bloom in her chest.

“What are you saying, Glim?”

“Well, I obviously know very little about this Catra character, but it sounds like there’s more to her than what meets the eye,” the Queen continued. “Is it possible that meeting a certain kind hearted blonde changed her mind about the Sisters’ war on She-Ra?”

Up until her betrayal, Catra had been nothing but good-tempered and coy with Adora. If she was in the business of trying to kill She-Ra, she had hidden it well. Despite the brevity of their encounter, Adora had grown to admire Catra - not just for her cocky smirk and long lashes, but for the passionate manner in which she encouraged Adora to seek out happiness of her own.

"When do you get to do what Adora *wants to do?"* Catra had asked.

Adora almost laughed out loud as she recalled her response. "*When the war is over, I guess*." Little did she know then that her destiny was the ferryman to the underworld and her life the obol that would grant her passageway across the River Styx.

Any fleeting notions of attraction towards Catra mattered little in the context of the fate of the universe.

"It doesn't matter anymore," she finally said.

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a worried look. "Uh, what do you mean, Adora?" the future King of Bright Moon questioned.

Adora stood and grabbed her bowl. "Whatever help Catra could have provided to the Rebellion doesn't matter anymore. There's no chance of her coming over to our side."

And there's no chance of her considering me anything more than just her next target.

"There's another war going on and I'll be damned if I don't play my part in it."

With that, she strode from the room, ignoring her friends' protests. She spent the remainder of the day oscillating between preparing the tablets for sale and training in the sparring ring with General Juliet. When she fell into bed that night, sleep immediately overtook her exhausted body.

She dreamt she was back in the Crystal Castle, surrounded by golden-hooded witches. The witch directly in front of her was taller than the rest, with crystal-blue arms and an expressionless mechanical face. She began to lift her head and Adora struggled to look away, knowing that there would be no turning back once the witch set her gaze upon Adora. The other witches rushed forward and held her in place, pinning her arms behind her back and pinching open her eyelids.

The witch in the middle met her gaze, then tilted her head. “Will you sink or swim, She-Ra?”

Adora woke up in a cold sweat to two hooded figures standing over her bed. They leaned forward to grab her roughly around the middle, likely to lead her away from Bright Moon and towards an inescapable destruction.

She didn’t stop them.

Catra’s ship came to a skidding halt as she landed among the soft grasses of Plumeria. She had spent the last twenty-four hours in a panicked rush attempting to locate Scorpia and her companions, as Entrapta was her fastest and most reliable hope at finding Adora before Shadow Weaver’s two week deadline was up.

Finding *She-Ra*, she reminded herself. Whatever pity she had begun to feel for the cute Rebellion soldier was long gone in the face of saving her own ass.

Even if said soldier had risked her own life to save Catra’s for no clear reason.

Catra dug her fingers into her palms, the stinging pain helping to refocus her mind on the mission before her. *Find the Black Garnet crew. Use whatever methods necessary to get the tech guru to locate She-Ra. Kill the Princess like you’ve killed countless people before.*

At the end of the day, Catra knew her aim would strike true. She was an assassin, through and through, and would not hesitate to take another’s life.

She scrambled out of her seat and quickly exited the cockpit. Instead of her ratty old freighter, she had taken one of Shadow Weaver’s newer ships, a compact model designed for stealth and speed. She climbed down the side of the ship and rushed towards the doors to Perfuma’s childhood home, ignoring the bewildered look of a gardener trimming rose bushes in the backyard.

When Scorpia had first told her that she was dating a Plumerian, Catra had been skeptical. A deeply noncommittal people, Plumeria refused to take sides in the war between the Horde and the Rebellion. Instead, they sat in their ivory towers and watched as the remainder of the universe squabbled and withered away.

But when Catra finally met Perfuma, a compassionate and spunky pilot, she rescinded all hesitations. Scorpia had a habit of looking at her girlfriend like she had put the stars in the sky, and that was enough for Catra.

It also didn't hurt that her family was massively wealthy and provided housing to Perfuma and her friends whenever they called upon them.

Which was why Catra was wrenching open the back doors and striding into Perfuma's family's mansion. "Perfuma? Entrapta?" she called out into the immaculate marble hallway. When she received no response, she jogged up the spiral staircase to the main floor. Whooloo, the Black Garnet's chief droid, was fixing a meal in the black-and white-tiled kitchen.

And wherever Whooloo went, Entrapta wasn't far behind.

She peeked her head into the kitchen. "Whooz, where's Entrapta?" she inquired.

The droid looked up from where he was frying eggs, flipping pancakes, and buttering toast at the same time. "Hello, Catra! I wasn't expecting you this morning. Would you also like some pancakes?"

The droid had poured two more scoops of batter onto the skillet before Catra could get a word out. "No, Whooz, I need to talk to Entrapta. Where is she?"

"Likely in the drawing room. She's been up for a while now," the droid explained.

Catra slapped the wall triumphantly. "Thanks, scrap metal."

Whooloo ‘tsked’ but didn’t reprimand her for the nickname. She was already halfway up the next set of stairs by the time he could respond anyways.

She marched past multiple vases of pink roses and several golden busts of deceased family members before she came upon an open doorway, the faint sound of someone humming drifting into the hallway. She didn’t bother knocking as she strode inside to find the Chief Engineer of the S.S. Black Garnet sitting at a desk, hunched over a large tablet displaying a sketch of a Thulite-powered engine.

“Hey, Entrapta,” Catra greeted.

Two lilac ponytails bounced as Entrapta turned her head to look over at the doorway.

“Catra!” She exclaimed, only somewhat apprehensively. Their past was complicated, to say the least, but Catra was hoping Entrapta wouldn’t hold that against her now in her time of dire need. “What are you doing here?”

“I actually have a mission I need your help with,” she admitted. “Can you locate someone for me?”

Entrapta swiped her hand on the screen and an interactive map replaced the sketch. “If I can locate Whooloo’s left buttock ten planets away I can locate your target. Who are they?”

Catra proceeded to recount every small detail she’d learned about Adora during their brief time together. She was in the middle of describing the scent of Adora’s shampoo (lavender and eucalyptus) on the off chance the information would be useful for Entrapta’s search, when a voice called out, “Ooh, is this your girlfriend?”

Catra frowned and turned to face the intruder. Perfuma leaned against the doorway, her long blonde hair tucked into a braid that rested atop one of her shoulders. Without her gloves and goggles, the pilot looked every bit the picture of a nobleman’s daughter -

perfectly rumpled pajamas, beautiful freckled skin, and an easy smile.

"No, this is my target," Catra explained.

"Oh," Perfuma said dejectedly. "It just sounded like you were talking about a crush."

"Who's to say it can't be both?" Entrapta mused, furiously typing away on her tablet. Perfuma looked at Catra expectantly.

"It's not," she said to Perfuma before turning and repeating herself to Entrapta. "It's *not*. Now do you have her location or what?"

The engineer continued typing for several seconds before pinching at the screen to zoom in and out on the map. "Yes, I've found her," she stated in a matter-of-fact tone. "But you're not going to like it."

Catra peered over her shoulder, attempting to decipher the series of overlapping red circles clustered in the corner of the screen. "What is it?"

Perfuma entered the room and came to stand behind Entrapta's other shoulder. "Oh my," she remarked. "Good luck with that."

Catra squinted to read the label on the map.

"The Crystal Castle"

She swallowed nervously. It was just her luck that She-Ra happened to be at the origin of her mysterious power - the impenetrable fortress of the Oracles of Light Hope.

"Nobody's ever infiltrated the Crystal Castle before and lived to tell the tale," Entrapta declared.

Catra took a deep breath. "That's why I'm going to be the first."

Perfuma gave her a disbelieving look. "Catra, please be careful."

She smirked. “I always am.” She glanced back down at the screen. “Can you send me these coordinates, Entrapta?”

The engineer’s fingers flew over the screen again. “On it!”

“Thanks.” She moved away from the desk as Perfuma called out, “This… *target* must be really important, huh?”

Catra halted in her tracks and turned back around. She hated the hopeful look Perfuma gave her. The pilot was obviously expecting Catra to confess her undying love for this woman and swear off the assassination. But that wasn’t how the world worked and Catra still had to kill She-Ra, *undying* love or not, if she wanted to live to see another day.

“You have no idea.”

Chapter End Notes

cue evil laughter Get ready for the final installation(s) y'all! Will Catra kill Adora? Will Adora surrender to Light Hope? Did Adora even get captured by Light Hope?!?! Stay tuned to find out ;D

Part V: How Rare and Beautiful It Is to Even Exist

Chapter Summary

> As multiple parties race towards the Crystal Castle, a deadly confrontation awaits.

Chapter Notes

> Hi, all :D Thanks for being patient with the updates for this story. I am so happy to be back today posting Part V and the Epilogue! I'll include more in the notes after the Epilogue, so for now, enjoy the story...

Catra double-checked, then *triple* -checked, that her daggers were in place. She had no reason to doubt her preparedness, as she had never once failed to properly arm herself for a mission, but Shadow Weaver's threat and the seemingly impossible task before her made her nervous in a way she could not fully explain.

Once she was certain she had not forgotten any of her weapons, she stuck her piton into the rock with a satisfying crunch. She slowly began to scale the cliffside below the Crystal Castle, not daring to peer over her shoulder to her ship resting in the sand below. If she knew how high she was, she'd likely vomit.

When she finally reached the top, she practically hurled her body over the edge. She lay among the worms for several minutes, allowing her heartbeat to slow and her muscles to cease their shaking. She hadn't slept in over forty-eight hours and had only scarfed down a stale pastry on the journey from Plumeria. She was long overdue for some rest and a hearty meal, but she didn't dare stop now.

She kept telling herself that she needed to complete the mission because her life depended on it. Besides, dying at the hands of

the Oracles of Light Hope was preferable when compared to spending an eternity in Shadow Weaver's scalding lava reservoir.

However, some part of her - some deep, naive part of her - wanted to pretend that Adora would be happy to see her; that Adora would take her in her arms and keep her safe from Shadow Weaver, the Reaper, and anyone else who wouldn't hesitate to kill her.

But that was just the exhaustion talking.

Catra sat up and gathered her climbing gear into a small knapsack that she hid behind a nearby rock. In the dim light of dawn, the imposing structure seemed nothing more than a glittering bluff overlooking a turquoise sea. She had read up on the Castle's security system before she arrived and was shocked to discover that most of the base actually resided underground. Its sprawling subterranean corridors were crafted from the most exquisite platinum and designed to keep their inhabitants cool against the midday heat of the triple suns.

What she had yet to figure out, though, was how to access these passageways.

She crept along the base of the Castle, careful that her steps didn't expose her to the security drones resting atop the tall spires. The last thing she needed was to get gunned down by one of those automated killing machines before she even had a chance to reach Adora.

As she moved, she slid her hand along the structure, searching for a crack or fissure or steel plate that felt out of place. She had almost turned the corner when her finger caught on a small bolt. She halted and retraced her finger's movement. Sure enough, a tiny chunk of platinum jutted out in that spot and three others.

Catra sank to her knees and gently rapped her knuckles against the wall. She turned so her ear was flat against the iridescent blue paneling and listened intently for even the faintest echo. When

she was confident she had located all the weak spots, she sank her nails into the wall and *pulled*.

It took a few tries, but eventually she wrenched open the panel. It had to be a maintenance cover or grate to a ventilation system of some kind. There were no guarantees that it would lead her to She-Ra, but her other options were pretty slim.

She tried to picture Adora's kind face at the end of the tunnel, raising her hand to her hat and tipping it like she had done when she met Catra for the first time.

But Catra wasn't there for Adora; she was there for *She-Ra*.

She crouched down on her knees and entered the passageway. "This is not because I like you," she said aloud to the phantom Adora, her voice resounding throughout the tunnel.

The apparition of Adora only blinked, then vanished.

"Hey, baby, guess who just set the Bright Moon record for the number of pies-"

Bow stopped in his tracks and glanced around the empty bedroom.

"Glimmer?" He called out.

"I'm in here!" A voice rang out from the bathroom. Bow made his way across the room, picking up several of Glimmer's discarded outfits as he went. He supposed that Glimmer was getting ready for bed early tonight, and he didn't blame her at all. These past few days - hell, these past few *months* - had been nothing but exhausting.

When he arrived, he found his fiancé loading a pouch of ammo into one of her revolvers, Micah. The bronze gun was fashioned in the style of one of her father's old weapons, with jagged golden stripes adorning the barrel in a lightning bolt pattern. He glanced

down on the marble countertop and saw Angella, a sleek black gun with two large pink stars painted on either side of the grip, resting beside what looked like a packed backpack.

So much for going to bed early.

Glimmer saw his gaze drift down towards the weapons. She finished loading her laser gun and turned to look at him, her face a mask of steely resolve. "Before you give me a lecture on how I'm the Queen now and need to stay in Bright Moon for my own safety, you'd do best to recall that it was *me* who saved you and Adora back on Krytis."

Bow sighed. "I know, and I'm grateful that you were monitoring our ship in case something bad happened, but why do you look like you're about to climb down into the pits of hell and slay the devil?"

Indeed she was dressed in an all-black ensemble, her pink and purple hair tied into two stubby pigtails at the top of her head.

"Because I am," Glimmer replied firmly. "Adora is missing and I think Light Hope took her."

Bow swallowed nervously. He had never heard anything good about Light Hope and her Oracles, even though they were supposedly assisting the Rebellion in the fight against supernatural forces of evil.

"Wait, Adora is missing?"

Glimmer nodded. "I went to check on her in her room and she was gone. Nobody's seen her since, and her tracker went down in deep space out near where we think the Crystal Castle is located." While she was speaking, Glimmer slid her revolvers into their holsters and grabbed her backpack. "You were too busy stuffing your face with pie to-"

"We weren't *eating* the pie, Glim, we were-"

She held up a hand. “I don’t want to know.”

She stepped forward and Bow wrapped his arms around her. “Just because I’m the Queen doesn’t mean that I let you guys have all the fun without me,” she said in a low voice.

Bow held her tight, relishing in the way that she nestled her head in the crook of his neck. “I know.” He pulled back and stared into her honey-brown eyes. “But I’d like to come with you. Adora is my friend too and has saved my life more times than I can count. It’s time I return the favor.”

Glimmer grinned wildly. “Good, ‘cause I packed your toothbrush and a set of fresh clothes in my bag. You can change on the way there, let’s go!”

She gave him a quick kiss on the cheek before marching out of the bathroom. Bow remained in place for a moment, bewildered that she had so expertly anticipated his reaction to the news about Adora, before he regained his senses and followed Glimmer to embark upon their perilous rescue mission.

Adora awoke to a pounding headache and a flash of blinding blue light. Although Light Hope’s henchwomen had drugged her, she didn’t need to look around to know that she was back in the Crystal Castle.

It was ironic that she had spent so long trying to escape from the fortress only to return somewhat willingly to give her life for the Oracles’ cause. She had grown up running around those winding corridors, learning about magic and making friends with the other Oracles-in-training.

But everything changed the day that Light Hope told her the truth regarding her parentage and her fate. Adora was descended from an extinct race of magical beings known as the First Ones. Before their untimely demise, the First Ones had crafted Light Hope, an

advanced form of artificial intelligence, with one purpose: to ensure that She-Ra fulfilled her destiny.

Light Hope had been less clear on that final part - her freakin' *destiny* - but Adora had gathered over the years that it involved a bargain with the universe; in order to fully halt the forces of evil encroaching upon all civilizations, She-Ra had to fully accept and master her powers. Only then could she activate the Heart of Etheria and restore balance to the universe.

Adora attempted to sit up but found her limbs uncooperative. She finally glanced down and noticed leather restraints binding her body to a slab of teal limestone hewn from the floor of the Castle.

She tilted her head back and forth to take in the completely new room of the Castle she had never seen before. Similar to the main gathering space, this cavern was large, with tall, imposing walls and a sloped ceiling. A pane of glass was fitted into the platinum paneling above her head to allow a shaft of bright blue light to encase her body in a cerulean coffin.

She noticed her sword resting against the wall next to the altar she lay upon. She closed her eyes and concentrated, trying to remember how it felt when she summoned She-Ra without the Sword of Protection. She grasped at the energy in her veins but it felt like she was trying to hold sand, the grains slipping through her fingers faster than she could catch.

A metallic clang resounded in the cavern and Adora quickly opened her eyes. She heard the familiar scrape of metal on metal before Light Hope, in all of her robotic glory, appeared above her.

"Good, you are awake," she said in her expressionless tone. "Now we can begin."

Catra was doing her best to ignore the beads of sweat dripping down her neck. She'd been crawling through the cramped passageway for about half an hour now and every inhale of warm,

sticky air only made her feel more trapped. *So much for these walls being designed to repel the blazing heat from the stupid three suns.*

She wiped her forehead with the back of her hand as she passed over a slanted grate. From beneath her knees, she heard several voices conversing loudly. She didn't dare exit yet, not when she could so easily be discovered by the throngs of witches living and training in the Castle. She was waiting for a grate located above a storage room or a closet where she could conspicuously dismount from the maintenance tunnel with the witches none the wiser.

She reluctantly passed the grate and continued onwards. She had an inkling of an idea about how to locate Adora, but it was risky and would likely result in one of the witches sounding an intruder alarm of some sort.

That being said, Catra would take rotting away in the Oracles' prison cell over an eternity at the mercy of Shadow Weaver and her painful, temperamental magic any day.

When she was younger, Catra dreamed of working off her debt to Shadow Weaver. She wondered if her parents knew what they were doing when they dropped her off on the doorstep of the most vicious and unforgiving witch in the universe. From the moment Catra had been able to hold a knife, Shadow Weaver had made her work as an assassin for ruthless clients, all to pay off the supposed costs of her lodging and meals.

Given how little she was fed and how shitty her living quarters were, Catra never understood how she hadn't earned enough to pay back Shadow Weaver.

Then she got older and realized that it wasn't about money, it was about control. Shadow Weaver relished in the control she maintained over Catra and her lucrative skills. She'd long since stopped pretending to balance Catra's cost of living with her total income and resorted to taking 80% of whatever Catra made on her missions.

Although Catra had more pocket change now, she still remained indentured to the witch with no easy manner to free herself.

If I ever escape from Shadow Weaver, I'll travel across the galaxy to find indentured servants and slaves and work to free them from their masters.

That was just her heat-addled mind speaking, though, because she had no means to escape somewhere far enough away that Shadow Weaver would never find her. What she really needed was to get out of that damned tunnel before she drowned in a sea of hopeless daydreams.

Catra continued crawling for another five minutes before she came across another grate in the shaft. She peered beneath and saw stacks of wooden boxes and several shelves filled to the brim with various vials and bottles.

She waited to see if she heard anyone in the room, but when all she received was silence, she went to remove the grate.

A hand on her shoulder stopped her.

Catra whirled around, banging her head against the top of the tunnel. Sitting cross-legged behind her was a young boy, about eight or nine in age with pale skin and hollow eyes. Upon his head twisted tendrils of flame, sizzling as they snaked forward to snatch her.

She jolted backwards. "Where the *krayt* did you come from?"

His hair kept its distance as he opened his mouth into a cruel smile. As his lips parted, Catra noticed rows upon rows of jagged teeth protruding from the top of his mouth and continuing down his throat. "Greetings, Catra."

The Reaper.

"It hasn't been two weeks-" she stumbled to get out. "I've almost got her-"

“Plans have changed.” He elegantly folded his hands in his lap. “The Great Weaver has requested that I devour your soul in forty-eight hours if you do not kill She-Ra, Princess of Power.”

Forty-eight hours? That’s barely any time at all.

Catra’s palms felt sticky as she clasped the bars of the grate. “I’m on it.”

He chuckled in a tenor much too low for someone who appeared less than a decade old. “I would hurry. The Great Weaver can be rather wrathful in her impatience.”

Catra yanked open the grate. “Thanks, flameboy.” She gave him a jaunty wave and dropped down into the storage closet. Her ankle twisted painfully underneath her, but she could still stand.

She brushed herself off and looked around the room. Perhaps there was something here she could use to disguise herself as an Oracle-in-training?

She didn’t have time to search for any garments, as the door flew open and a worried girl strode in. “Martha? We heard some noises and-”

She halted, frozen in the doorway as she took in Catra. She brought her hand to her chest and let out a high-pitched scream.

“Really, princess?” Catra complained. She heard footsteps approaching and knew she couldn’t ponder any longer - it was time to enact her risky plan.

She lunged forward and grabbed the Oracle-in-training before the girl could come to her senses and use her magic on Catra. She pressed the girl’s back to her stomach and whipped out one of her daggers to rest against the side of her throat. The girl’s shrieking immediately stopped.

Several worried faces soon appeared in the doorway. Once they caught sight of Catra, they all gasped.

“Listen carefully,” Catra said gruffly. “If any of you let out another gods-damned scream, I will slit this precious girl’s throat. Am I understood?”

They all nodded, save for one stout girl in the back who cupped her hands together in an obvious attempt to summon her magic. “And I have a magic ward on so don’t bother trying with any of that shit,” Catra lied. The girl let her hands fall to her sides, and Catra breathed a sigh of relief.

“I’m here for She-Ra. Can you tell me where she is?”

The Oracles-in-training looked among each other. The one whom Catra held tight in her grasp ventured, “We didn’t know She-Ra was back.”

“If she’s back, then Mistress Light Hope will likely start the ceremony. We should prepare,” another offered.

“What ceremony?” Catra inquired. When the girls were silent, she pressed her knife even tighter against the girl’s skin. A droplet of blood emerged and slid down the side of her neck.

“Th-the ceremony to activate the Heart of Etheria,” a tall girl in the front stuttered nervously. “To finally fulfil the goal of the Oracles, She-Ra must activate the Heart of Etheria.”

Catra had never heard of the Heart of Etheria before but, based on the context, it was likely some grand weapon that would grant She-Ra immense power.

She needed to stop that ceremony, *fast*.

“And where can I expect this ceremony to take place?”

Bow yelped as he dodged a blast from one of the vicious sniper drones. After crash-landing on the front doorstep of the Crystal Castle, he, Glimmer, and MDA3 were finding it extremely difficult to infiltrate the Oracles’ headquarters and rescue Adora.

He leapt behind a particularly large rock and savored the brief respite from the gunfire to catch his breath. As they were entering the atmosphere of this despondent planet on the edge of the galaxy, he'd observed two ships parked down in the sand beneath a large cliff. One was compact and painted a deep onyx while the other was outfitted in the red and white colors of a Horde military vessel.

Unluckily, it seemed like he and Glimmer weren't the only ones attempting to infiltrate the most impenetrable fortress in the universe today. Luckily, whoever had come before them blasted a large hole in the side of the structure. He, Glimmer, and MDA3 were running towards that hole when the sniper drones started shooting.

"Bow!" Glimmer called out. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine! Are you okay?" He dared to peek around the corner of the rock and saw that she had already made it to the gaping hole in the wall. MDA3 beeped worriedly from their position behind Glimmer's leg.

"Yes, but hurry!" She pointed up and Bow watched as the drones slowly rose into the air and lurched forward. He probably had less than ten seconds before they reached him.

He wasted no time in sprinting towards Glimmer, attempting to zig-zag as he went to throw off their aim. He cried out in pain as a stray bullet grazed past his thigh, but made it to Glimmer without further incident.

"Your leg-" she started and he waved her off.

"We need to go. Who's to say they won't keep following us?" He pointed out. Glimmer opened her mouth to argue, but promptly shut it and hurried into the building. Bow followed behind, pressing his hand to his thigh to try and slow the bleeding. MDA3 let out a series of chirps as they rolled in front of Glimmer. Bow's heart twisted at the droid's thoughtful and brave behaviour in

taking the lead. He only hoped it wouldn't cost MD another one of his many useful appendages.

MDA3 maneuvered them down a narrow passageway and into a large courtyard. Multicolored banners affixed to golden stands waved in a phantom breeze as Bow counted six separate arches surrounding the platinum plaza. As he approached, he noticed a series of lines and circles on each banner, likely spelling out words in some ancient language only his dads would understand.

Glimmer messily ripped off the arm of her jacket and tied it around his thigh as he took in the arches. There was a scorch mark above one arch adjacent to the passageway they'd entered through. "That way," he said.

Glimmer followed his line of sight even as her fingers expertly worked to craft a tourniquet in the skin above his wound. He was grateful for her battlefield training, although it made him sad to think about how she had gained such knowledge from spending almost a decade fighting on the front lines as a Commander in her mother's war.

"Perfect," she responded. She finished up the tourniquet and grabbed his hand. They chased MDA3 down the tunnel, the increasing buzz of the drones behind them prompting Bow to worry that the automated snipers were almost on their heels.

MDA3 turned a corner and let out a shrieking "BEEEEP!" Glimmer whipped out her revolvers as Bow cautiously peeked around the corner. MD had knocked someone to the ground and was now attempting to extricate themselves from that person's limbs.

As the other person scrambled to their feet, Bow took in the short chestnut hair, black leather jacket, and ferocious glare.

"Catra?" he said, dumbfounded.

"Don't look so happy to see me," she grumbled, holding a knife out in front of her with one hand. She eyed MD warily before

turning her gaze on Glimmer. “I see you brought Sparkles with you.”

“It’s *Glimmer*, not Sparkles. And what are you doing here?” Glimmer questioned, leveling her gun at Catra’s head.

“I could ask you the same thing,” the assassin responded, tightening her grip on her knife.

“Hold on,” Bow waved his hands in the air. “Let’s just put the weapons down and have a nice, civil discussion.”

Neither girl obeyed.

“You did a pretty shitty job of blasting open the front doors,” Glimmer scorned.

Catra’s confusion was apparent in the way her brows furrowed. “I didn’t blast open anything.”

Before anyone could offer an explanation, the buzz of the drones increased to an almost unbearable roar. Bow took a chance and ran behind Catra towards what he assumed was the main hallway. As he predicted, she didn’t make any moves to stab him.

Noticing this, Glimmer dropped her guns and sprinted after Bow, MDA3 close behind her.

It wasn’t until they had turned another corner that Bow realized Catra had followed him as well. He didn’t have the mental capacity to both outrun the drones and consider why she happened to be in the Crystal Castle, but he could only assume her intentions were less than pure.

When they reached another courtyard, they finally ran into some of the inhabitants of the Castle. Five girls wearing golden robes stood to their feet as the three of them rushed in. The remnants of a meal were scattered on a wooden table before them.

Glimmer put her hand on her hip and aimed one of her guns towards the ceiling. Seconds later a loud boom resounded in the courtyard and chunks of platinum plating fell onto the table. “Scram,” Glimmer warned the Oracles-in-training. They dutifully rushed away through one of the many arches.

Bow turned in a complete circle, unsure of which path to take. He glanced back over at Catra and Glimmer to see the former pull a compass out of her pocket. She angled her body to the left then put the compass away.

She moved towards one of the arches, but Glimmer caught her by the arm. “What do you plan on doing with Adora? I know you’re here for her.”

Catra yanked herself out of Glimmer’s grasp. “I’ll do what needs to be done. For your own good, you should stay out of my way.”

She trudged forward, but MDA3 rolled into her path. Catra called the droid a whole host of curse words Bow had never heard before and pushed past them. MD chirped half-heartedly and came to rest next to Bow’s uninjured leg. Once Catra had exited the courtyard, Bow turned to Glimmer.

“Bow, I know how we’re going to locate Adora,” Glimmer said smugly. “Because we’ve just found the one person that can’t seem to stay away from her.”

Adora blinked up at the robotic face before her. Three years apart was not enough time for her to forget Light Hope’s violet-blue metallic skin etched with First Ones’ writing. She scowled as she regarded Adora like one might regard the lamb they planned to slaughter: with a restrained yet vicious hunger.

“After a thousand years, my programming will be fulfilled,” Light Hope declared. From behind her, Adora heard the clang of a door opening followed by the shuffling of many sets of bare feet and long robes. “She-Ra has returned to unleash the Heart of Etheria!”

Triumphant cries resounded in the cavern around her. Adora peered around Light Hope to find herself surrounded by dozens of golden-hooded witches.

"You don't have to keep me restrained, Light Hope," Adora stated. "I've come willingly. I *want* to help save the universe."

"First you must demonstrate your worthiness," the robot explained. "Summon She-Ra without the sword and free yourself from these bonds."

Adora wanted to roll her eyes. *Another test?* Light Hope had always been quizzing her during her training with the Oracles, testing her knowledge of their sacred order at every twist and turn.

"Fine," she responded and relaxed her head back down onto the stone. She took a deep breath, faintly catching a whiff of incense floating through the cavern, and opened her palms up towards the sky. The blue light burned against her closed eyelids as she dug deep into the marrow of her bones for the magical energy that she possessed regardless of her affinity with She-Ra.

Sure enough, the sand crystals hardened into rock, then into a pulsing power that radiated from her every pore. She burned brighter than the three suns as she toasted the restraints keeping her in place and rose above the altar. In that moment, she could destroy planets, she could create life. Adora was She-Ra and She-Ra was *power*.

As soon as she opened her eyes, she fell to the ground, her knees slamming against the unforgiving stone. She felt drained, devoid of all of her magic like somebody had inserted a tube into her bloodstream and sucked all of her insides out.

She looked up to Light Hope, confused. The robot turned and revealed the glowing Sword of Protection within her grasp.

"What happened? What did you do?" Adora spat out.

“Restrain her,” Light Hope ordered and the witches surrounded Adora. She fought them off as best as she could, but she could barely stand on her limbs that curled like noodles underneath her weight. The Oracles swiftly restrained her with a new set of metal bindings that they chained into the floor.

“Wait, Light Hope! What are you doing?” She shouted as her former mentor turned her back to Adora and approached a giant panel set into the teal platinum of the opposing wall.

“I am fulfilling my intended function. So are you.” She turned back to Adora. “You have helped activate the Heart of Etheria. It is what you were born to do.”

“But the Heart of Etheria is supposed to bring balance to the universe,” Adora stated.

“That was a child’s tale. You didn’t think I would tell a twelve year-old the true purpose of this great First Ones’ weapon?”

At Adora’s confused stare, Light Hope tilted her head. “That was a rhetorical question. I am sorry if you did not understand. Let me clarify: The Light Hope Operating System was designed to nurture She-Ra to her full capacity and then use the Sword of Protection to destroy the First Ones’ enemies.”

Adora was almost afraid to ask, but she needed to know. “Who are the First Ones’ enemies?”

“The Horde,” Light Hope explained. Adora stopped struggling against her bonds. Maybe her former mentor wasn’t as misguided as she had begun to assume.

“The Rebellion,” Light Hope continued and Adora’s heart sank. “All of humanity. They drove the First Ones to extinction, forcing the great leaders to open up a rift in spacetime and send me and you to a parallel universe, a universe where the First Ones still have a chance to survive.”

Light Hope placed the Sword of Protection into a slot in the wall. "I am only trying to help your people, Adora. I assumed you would be grateful."

Adora let out a disbelieving laugh. "By destroying all of humanity, you'll send this universe into complete chaos. How is that better for the First Ones?"

"There is no use arguing." The Sword began to glow with a multicolored light. "It is already done."

"No, I won't let you," Adora argued and tried to summon She-Ra again. While she'd felt an inkling of her power before, this time she felt absolutely nothing.

Panic began to rise in her chest. Light Hope pressed several buttons on the panel and the Sword's rainbow aura began to illuminate the large cavern. Adora thrashed out against her restraints, screaming at the top of her lungs. "Please, Light Hope! You can't do this! If you resort to mass murder, you'll be no better than the people who killed the First Ones!"

"Finish her," Light Hope commanded in a deadly tone. A cluster of four witches approached the altar, one of them drawing a slender knife from her robe.

Adora fell silent after the first stab. She stopped moving after the second.

Catra pushed open the door to the ceremony chamber and was immediately met with almost one hundred stunned faces. Somewhere in the distance, a rainbow light emanated from a large slit in the wall. If she squinted, she could make out an altar in the middle of the light, and a bloody corpse atop that.

She had her whip out before she even knew what she was doing. She mowed down the witches, golden arms and legs catching in her trap before she sliced their throats. She knew Bow and the sparkly Queen were hot on her heels, but there were more than

enough witches here for the three of them plus that stupid Bright Moon droid.

"What is happening?" A booming voice called out as the witches shrieked. Catra glanced up and saw the silhouette of a tall, slender woman among the dazzling, multicolored glow.

"We are capturing She-Ra for the Horde!" Another voice called out from behind Catra. She whipped her head around and saw that a third party had joined them in the cavern, a group of Horde soldiers led by a short girl with dreadlocks and a green-skinned lizard.

"No, She-Ra belongs to the Rebellion!" Bow's sparkly companion shouted as she kicked an oncoming witch out of her way.

The two groups charged towards each other, wading through the golden sea of Oracles. The girl with dreadlocks whipped out a taser and zapped each witch that stood in her path. The lizard-man, who carried a surprisingly large gun, ran through the crowd towards Catra.

Catra cursed and rolled out of the way as he barreled past. When he didn't turn around, she realized that he was heading towards the altar. Catra sliced the wrist of a witch attempting to cast a spell on her and raced after him.

When she approached the back wall, she realized that the figure standing before the altar was a robot of some kind, with violet and blue plating underneath furrowed eyebrows.

"She-Ra is no more," the robot-woman called out in a loud voice. Catra swore the battle around her stopped for a brief moment. *Could she be telling the truth? Maybe I won't have to worry about whether or not I have what it takes to kill Adora because she's already dead.*

She didn't have time to consider the robot's words any further, as the lizard-man began shooting at her. Between dodging his bullets and the well-timed magic blasts from the witches, Catra was

beginning to think that barging head-first into the Crystal Castle was a mistake.

But as she ducked behind the altar to avoid another blast, her face met someone's cool flesh. She pulled back and saw a hand dangling from the side of the elevated surface. Catra rose up to get a glance of the body and felt the world fall out from underneath her.

Adora - her eyes closed and a pool of blood underneath her abdomen - lay unmoving upon the rock. In her stillness, she appeared much younger, all of the hard lines from her forehead evaporated into a smooth plane. Her lips were parted ever-so-slightly, and Catra felt a sob catch in her throat.

She turned her back to the lizard-man and the witches, consequences be damned, and caught Glimmer's eye from across the battlefield. Whatever Glimmer saw in Catra's gaze made the Queen let out a piercing wail and charge towards the altar.

Catra sank to her knees. "She's dead," she said aloud. Shadow Weaver got her wish after all, and Catra didn't even have to do the hard part. She should feel joyful, elated, *deliriously happy* - but instead all she felt was a chilling numbness that spread to the tips of her fingers and toes.

"She's dead," Catra repeated.

"She has done her duty," the robot responded. "The Heart is now primed and ready. Commencing activation in five… four… three…"

She didn't get a chance to finish, as the Queen of Bright Moon leapt up and shot a hole in the back of the robot's head. Catra sprung into action alongside her, capturing the robot's legs with her whip and causing her to fall flat on her mechanical face. The lizard-man stood by as Bow rushed past him and sank an arrow into the robot's back. Lightning crackled from the arrowhead to encase her entire body, leaving it smouldering and charred after the electric infection finished its course.

All of the witches that could see the spectacle let out mournful, lamenting cries and rushed to engage Catra's little group in combat. The fighting resumed, this time with the Horde soldiers attempting to retreat from the room and Bow, Glimmer, and MDA3 holding their ground by the altar.

Catra didn't bother to join in. She couldn't feel anything anymore, not with Adora gone.

She wasn't foolish enough to label her feelings towards the other girl as *love*, but she wasn't naive enough to deny that she had started to entertain those thoughts. Meeting Adora was a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, not because she presented Catra with a way to please Shadow Weaver but because she was incredible just by being herself. Adora was compassionate, and dedicated, and strong. Catra could tell that she put 110% into each task she was given, fully and diligently serving the people around her with an indestructible empathy.

And if anyone could survive what looked like several jabs to the gut, it was Adora.

Catra knocked aside a witch and strode to the altar. She grabbed Adora's hand and pressed it to her cheek. "Hey, sweetheart. It's Catra. Can you hear me?"

When there was no response, Catra felt tears begin to drip down her cheeks. "You have to wake up," she ordered, her throat catching on a sob. "Adora, please, you *have* to."

Still no response.

That's when Catra realized that she was surrounded by a rainbow light emanating from a golden hilt sticking out of the paneling along the back wall.

The Sword! Adora healed herself from Huntara's poison darts before by transforming into She-Ra. If I give her the Sword, maybe she'll be able to transform and heal herself again!

Catra reluctantly dropped Adora's hand and walked over the control panel. She yanked at the Sword with all of her might, but it would not budge.

"C'mon, you stupid fucking sword!" She shouted, half-sobbing.

"Catra, what are you doing?" Bow called out as he shot an arrow at an enraged witch.

"The Sword, maybe it can-" she didn't have to finish before he rushed over and wrapped his hands around the handle. Together they pulled the Sword out of its resting place, the rainbow light suddenly dissipating, leaving Catra's hands with a stinging burn. Bow yelped and retracted his hands from the metal, but Catra let the sword scorch her flesh as she rushed back over to Adora.

In the distance, she noticed the Horde soldiers halt their retreat, their eyes eagerly affixed on Catra's every move. They probably wanted She-Ra to come back to life so they could use her as a weapon in their war against Bright Moon.

Which was probably what Bow and Glimmer wanted as well - the glorious Princess of Power to champion their kingdom's cause and lead them to victory and prosperity.

But what Catra wanted, wholly and deeply, was for Adora to finally get a chance to make her own destiny. No more serving as a pawn in others' battles, but instead seeking out the things that make *her* happy.

So, instead of placing the Sword next to Adora and speaking some hopeless, encouraging words to get the girl to transform back into She-Ra, Catra threw the Sword on the ground with all of her might and shattered it.

The witches near her shielded their faces as the gilded fractures sang through the air, piercing and scraping any exposed flesh. Catra embraced the pain, the pin-pricks of metal shards dancing upon her skin. If she couldn't bring Adora peace in this life, at least she could guarantee her peace in death.

The fighting truly stopped after that. Glimmer stepped forward and grabbed the unbroken hilt of the Sword of Protection. She glared at Catra.

"What have you done?"

Adora couldn't feel her toes. Logically, she knew they were still attached to her feet, but she couldn't get them to *move*.

C'mon, get up! She told herself, but her body disobeyed.

She dared a glance down to where her body should be and found nothing save for the limestone of the altar. In fact, when she glanced left and right she found the ceremony chamber completely empty.

The floor beneath her let out a mighty groan as it began to descend into a dark abyss. Adora scrambled for purchase on the altar before she realized that she had no body and was merely a sliver of her former consciousness.

And instead of sinking into the ground with the floor, she was rising towards the blue skylight.

She began to panic. Either method of exiting the chamber - sky-bound through the glass above or underground through the cavernous abyss below - did not seem appealing.

I can't go - there's something I'm supposed to do… someone I'm supposed to save?

She couldn't recall, but she knew that it wasn't time for her to leave the atria of the living just yet.

So she fought the only way she knew how - with all of her strength. She concentrated on the slick coolness of the limestone altar beneath her back, the sharp pain in her abdomen from the witch's blade. She focused on Light Hope and the Sword, of her

childhood in the Crystal Castle. She focused on those that she cared about: on Bow, and Glimmer, and *Catra*.

Suddenly, Adora knew she wasn't alone.

She ceased her mental straining to allow herself to perceive the figure that appeared before her. They wore the golden robes of the Oracles, but stood with a dignified grace that none of Light Hope's pupils ever achieved. The tip of a long brunette braid peeked out from behind the hood and twin steel orbs pierced her with a sharp, but not unkind, gaze.

It took Adora a moment to realize who exactly was floating alongside her as the cavern sank below.

"Mara?" As soon as the thought hit her, her voice resounded throughout the chamber.

"Hello, Adora," Mara responded, tilting back her hood to display a grim smile. "It's such a shame that we meet again under these circumstances."

"Which are…?"

"You are dying, Adora." Adora felt the panic return in full force, manifesting in a sweeping wind that sent her consciousness careening towards the sinkhole. Her scream echoed inside her phantom mind.

Suddenly, she halted. Mara's arms had wrapped around her spirit and were pulling her back towards the middle of the chamber. Although Adora had no body, Mara's embrace warmed her.

"Where am I?" she questioned. *"And what are* you *doing here?"*

The figure of Mara sighed. "This place is… difficult to explain. Light Hope banished me here when I found out the truth about her intentions with the Sword of Protection."

Her form flickered for a moment before returning with a weaker hue.

"I sense that Light Hope has activated the Heart of Etheria. With its power, with *She-Ra's* power, she can destroy the galaxy with just a snap of her fingers. We need to stop her."

"What do we do?"

"Do you see that light?" Mara pointed to the piercing blue beams barreling down from the chamber ceiling.

"Yes."

"That's the source of She-Ra's magic. It's threatening to rip through this realm and into yours. Light Hope is creating a portal with each twist of the Sword. The only way to stop the power transfer is for you to-" Mara suddenly stopped, clutching at her chest. Adora wanted to leap forward and help, but she was still non-corporeal.

"The Sword, something's happening to it," Mara gasped. She looked up at Adora with wide eyes. "*Go*, Adora. *Go*!"

And with that, Mara dissipated. When a chunk of the ceiling fell into the space where Mara had been floating, Adora realized that the entire chamber was collapsing. Mara hadn't gotten a chance to finish her instructions, but Adora had a feeling that she knew what needed to be done.

I guess all I was ever meant to be was a sacrifice, back in my realm and in this one.

She focused with all of her might on the patch of blue light. Less than a heartbeat later, she was enveloped in a luminescent cocoon. She noticed a gleaming gold object above her and urged her spirit to float up towards it.

As she approached, she realized that the object was a solid gold replica of the Sword of Protection. Adora steeled herself amidst

the chunks of ceiling falling around her and, with her mind, grasped the hilt.

Suddenly she could see the chamber again, full of witches and Horde soldiers and Adora's friends. Through the fabric of spacetime, Adora watched as three different versions of Glimmer leapt upon the altar and shot Light Hope in the back of the head. She observed Catra's emotional aura flicker in rage as she tripped Light Hope with her whip, and contemplated Bow's heartbeat and blood pressure as he slammed an electric arrow into the robot's metal casing, causing her to short circuit at an alarming rate.

After a moment (Maybe two? Maybe a week? Adora couldn't tell anymore) Catra approached the altar. MDA3 rushed to her side as a bullet struck one of their appendages instead of Catra's leg. Adora knew that the mangled body that lay upon the altar was her own, but it was still odd to watch Catra sink to her knees and grasp the corpse's hand.

It's good that I won't survive whatever this is, she thought as she eyed the blood dripping from the altar to the floor. *Because I don't know how I'd ever recover from those wounds.*

Catra suddenly leapt up from the altar and rushed over to the Sword of Protection. She and Bow yanked it free from the slot in the wall and Adora sensed Catra's hesitation as she turned back around to face the altar. In a transcendent moment, Adora saw through Catra's eyes, registering all of the emotions flitting through her mind.

One stood out among the others - a need to *protect*.

The assassin may have betrayed Adora, but she cared enough about her to consider the unthinkable, to make a choice that Bow or Glimmer might not be strong enough to make.

So Catra, with a defiant love and defensive fury, raised the sword above her head and slammed it into the ground.

As soon as the tip of the sword touched the stone floor, Adora was transported back to the in-between realm, the collapsing chamber that grew colder and colder without Mara's embrace. The golden sword in front of her began to melt, causing Adora to panic and attempt to catch its drippings in the net of her consciousness to no avail.

When the final stream of golden liquid vanished, Adora felt the chamber still. The blinding light began to fade as she floated down towards the broken altar. Once she arrived, Mara appeared again. This time, the young woman was free of her golden robes and sported a blue tunic and gold arm bands.

"Your friends truly are exceptional," she gushed. "They've helped free your universe of She-Ra's power, a might too awesome and corruptible for the small minds contained within. No offense, of course."

"None taken. So is this where I finally die?" Adora inquired.

"The choice is yours. As the last beholder of the Sword of Protection, you are granted free passage to the universe of its creation. *Your* mind can withstand the power, meaning you can live out the rest of your days as She-Ra, Princess of Power, on your home planet."

Adora perked up.

"With your parents," Mara added. "And brother."

She almost didn't even want to hear her other options. Meeting her family and learning more about her origins was a dream Adora had harbored since she was a child.

"Let's go."

"Hold on," Mara put a hand up. "You can also choose to return to your universe with no magical abilities at all. She-Ra's energy will heal you of your deadly wounds, but you will no longer be able to summon her strength."

Adora was about to ask why Mara had even bothered to state the second offer when a wave of longing overcame her. She thought of Glimmer, Bow, Catra, and MDA3 all putting their lives at risk for her sake. During that brief transcendental moment before, she had gained an understanding of their emotions, of the *love* that each one of them held for her.

Could she really give up on the people that had given her so much? Could she really turn away a broken yet rewarding reality just for the chance at happiness with a family who would only ever see her as She-Ra, not Adora?

She had already drunk from the poisoned chalice too many times to take that risk. So, she focused on Mara's beautiful face and replied with an ardent confidence, *"I'm stronger than you know. Take me back."*

"What have you done?"

Glimmer's words echoed in Catra's ears. She felt blood and tears slide down her face as she stumbled forward, woozy from her wounds. Glimmer helped her to the ground. "I did what needed to be done." She let out a clipped laugh and raised her hand to brush her thumb against a cut on Glimmer's bicep. "Didn't I say it was for your own good to stay out of my way?"

Glimmer fixed her with a hard stare. "You just took away the *one* chance we had at bringing Adora back!"

"Bringing Adora back or bringing She-Ra back?" Catra pushed. "Do you see her as anything more than a weapon to help win your petty little war?"

"Of course I do," Glimmer replied, her voice scratchy. Tears began to fall down her cheeks as well. "I *love* Adora. She's my best friend, above everything else. Even if she never fights for the Rebellion again, I will always love her."

Bow stepped forward and placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. She rose from a crouch and approached the altar, stepping into the blue light of day that rained down from the ceiling to mock Adora's corpse with its liveliness.

Catra watched as Glimmer placed the hilt of the sword in between Adora's hands, resting them on her stomach. The Bright Moon droid let out a sad beep and rolled over to the side of the altar.

"Your friend died a hero," one of the witches offered. "Her death was meant to bring balance to the universe."

"Not her death," Bow added. " *She-Ra*'s death. Adora should still be here; she *deserves* to still be here."

The witch opened her mouth to say more but paused, a curious look growing on her face. Catra followed her gaze to the altar and noticed a golden light emanating from Adora's clasped hands. Hope - stupid, reckless hope - blossomed in Catra's chest as the light encased Adora's body. The chains around her ankles and wrists snapped open and Adora's body hovered above the altar, showered in the blue sunlight.

Suddenly, Adora's eyes snapped open. Pure golden light radiated from her eye sockets and beneath her skin, causing Catra to shield her eyes and look away. When the light faded, Catra glanced back over to see Adora kneeling atop the stone. Adora took a shuddering breath and began to cough up blood.

Bow and Glimmer rushed forward before she could fall off the altar. She blinked and looked directly at Catra, her blue irises rimmed with gold.

Catra's heart leapt into her throat. *Is that you? Is that* Adora?

"Adora! Are you okay?" Bow exclaimed.

Adora lifted up the bottom of her shirt to reveal a bloody but fully intact stomach. "Yes, I think so," she uttered. Glimmer and Bow wrapped their arms around her in a fierce hug.

“Is that She-Ra?” the girl with the dreadlocks called out, already approaching the altar with a vicious gleam in her eyes.

“No,” Adora called out. “She-Ra’s gone. I used the last of her magic to heal myself. It’s all gone.”

The Horde soldier shared a glance with her lizard companion. “Then consider this a gracious offer, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, that we do not seek to capture you and take you to Lord Hordak right now.” She gave them all a final nod before turning and retreating from the cavern.

As they walked away, Glimmer muttered under her breath. “Like you could take me in a fight, you little bitch.”

Adora slowly pushed herself off the altar and tossed the former hilt of the Sword of Protection into the air.

“What are you going to do with that?” Bow inquired as Adora caught the hilt with her other hand.

“Are you our new leader now, mistress?” a witch questioned.

“Should you really be walking? You literally just *died*, Adora,” Glimmer pointed out.

Adora didn’t seem to listen to any of them. A newfound confidence radiated off of her as she walked over and helped Catra to her feet.

“Thanks, darlin’,” Catra attempted to say in an even tone, but her voice betrayed her emotions.

Adora reached up to tilt her hat at Catra and, finding herself without it, let out a melodic laugh. “Anytime, love.”

Catra felt the corner of her mouth quirk up into a smile from the nickname. “That’s a new one.”

“I learned from the best,” Adora winked at her before placing the hilt of the Sword in her hands and turning back to Bow and Glimmer.

“So how long was I dead for?” she inquired, putting an arm around their shoulders and leading them away from the altar. Catra glanced down at the hilt. It seemed so plain now that it was detached from the Sword of Protection, but Catra still felt wrong with it in her grasp.

One of the nearby witches turned to her. “Are *you* our new lead-”

Catra didn’t let her finish.

“Don’t.”

Epilogue: The Universe was Made Just to be Seen by Your Eyes

Chapter Summary

A waterside discussion about future plans. Set after Parts I-V.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sighed as she dipped her toes in the water. Once, a day spent lounging in the hot springs of Mystacor would have stressed her out to no end - *Why spend that time in the water when I could be training? What if I miss something important in the fight against the Horde?* - but now she relished in the calming sensation of hours passing by smoother than silk and sweeter than honey.

It helped that she had good company. Even if said company was currently kicking her in the shin.

"C'mon, Adora. I'm hungry," Catra complained.

Adora kept her eyes closed as she leaned back against the edge of the tub. "Mmm, another five minutes."

She heard Catra's exasperated sigh. Bow and Glimmer had left the springs half an hour ago, but Catra refused to go with them, even though she had been protesting the lack of food for the entire afternoon. In fact, ever since the incident in the Crystal Castle, Catra had remained close to Adora's side, never smothering her but always within short distance.

Adora had to admit, being around Catra was fun, as the bandit never had a shortage of snarky comments and random games that made their days-long journeys across the galaxy extremely entertaining. Although the war between the Rebellion and Horde still raged on, and Catra's former mentor was still alive and

vengeful, Adora tried to relish in the small joys, such as the cute manner in which Catra snorted whenever she laughed or the way that her cheeks flushed whenever Adora used an endearing nickname.

They hadn't put any labels on whatever was going on between them, but Adora didn't feel the need to. She had all the time in the world now, and was going to spend that doing whatever she wanted whenever she wanted.

"We've been here so long Shadow Weaver is going to find me," Catra said, finally prompting Adora to open her eyes.

"Are you really worried about that?" Adora asked in a soft voice. Despite the steam from the springs, she could make out thousands of tiny freckles on Catra's arms and chest. Adora didn't dare let her eyes drop any further down, despite her curiosity to see the extent to which the small constellations adorned her skin.

"Not really," Catra said dismissively, which was Adora's cue that something was up.

She glided through the water so she could sit on the bench next to Catra. She lifted a hand out of the water and smooth back a stray piece of her short hair. "She-Ra is gone. You don't owe anything to Shadow Weaver any more."

"I know, I just can't shake the feeling that she's still looking for me," Catra admitted. She shrugged. "After twenty-something years of her breathing down my neck, it feels weird to not have her looming presence over me, you know?"

Adora knew better than most. After breaking from Light Hope's prophecy and forming her own destiny apart from the supposed fate of She-Ra, she often found herself anxious due to the *lack* of that dark presence looming over her head and pervading her every waking thought.

"Yeah," she responded. "But if she really wanted you back, wouldn't she have sent the Reaper already?"

Catra looked forlornly off into the distance. “Maybe she’s just biding her time and waiting for an opportune moment to suck out my soul.”

Adora sighed. “Well, take it from someone who’s died- it’s not all it’s cracked up to be.”

Catra rolled her eyes and glanced over at Adora with a fond smile. “You say that so lightly but…” Catra hesitated and Adora could tell that she was struggling to form the words to ask her about something that had been bothering her since the Crystal Castle.

“What happened when you died?” Catra whispered. “Could you hear anything I said?”

“Why? Any confessions of undying love I should know about?” Adora teased. Catra shoved her shoulder and splashed her lightly.

“You wish, sweetheart.”

Adora settled back into her spot and let her arm brush against Catra’s. Underneath the water, she found the other girl’s hand and intertwined their fingers. She wasn’t ready to tell the full story just yet, but she could at least be honest about certain elements.

“I couldn’t hear you but I could see your emotions. It’s kind of hard to explain,” she started. Catra nodded, following along intently. “I knew that you shattered the sword because you wanted what was best for me; I *felt* that.”

Catra gave her hand a squeeze, emboldening Adora to continue.

“She-Ra’s magic is- *was*- a lot more powerful than I ever knew. In the end it offered me a choice, and I took the one that led me back to the path of the living.”

“But without She-Ra’s power?” Catra pressed. Adora had a feeling that Catra knew about the consequential decision that she had been forced to make in the twilight zone between death and life.

Adora squeezed Catra's hand back. "Without She-Ra's power."

Catra slowly leaned down and placed her head on Adora's shoulder. The two of them remained in silence for several peaceful moments before Catra finally said. "Just because I want what's best for you doesn't mean that I also don't want what's best for me."

Adora scoffed. "How does that work?"

Catra sat up and faced Adora. Even after hours in the water, she was brilliantly beautiful, a heart of eternal loveliness wrapped inside a tough exterior. "Well, *you* want to see all the planets and *I* want to liberate indentured servants all over the galaxy."

She gave Adora a blinding smile. "Maybe we'll start with Shesir, or Chari."

Adora's heart soared as she imagined sailing through space with Catra and MDA3 (whom the former assassin had begrudgingly started to tolerate.) Although they would still help Glimmer and Bow with the Rebellion's war against the Horde, they had their *own* mission, something that just the two of them could dedicate their lives to. Adora hadn't ever had the freedom to picture her own future before, but now that she did, she knew without a shadow of a doubt that it would include Catra.

She could only return Catra's smile tenfold in response. "Sounds perfect."

Chapter End Notes

> Wow I cannot believe we're at the end of this little tale. This fic was so incredibly fun to write and I hope that you all have enjoyed it (even if I was mean and made you think Adora was going to die for a little bit :P) Thank you for your support and comments/kudos along the way, I wouldn't still be writing if it wasn't for you all! <3 Now who knows what story I'll end up writing next...

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!